

Resumen

Este Trabajo de Fin de Máster presenta un estudio sobre el diseño, fabricación y caracterización de celdas de vapor escritas por láser (LWVCs), sensores atómicos miniaturizados completamente de vidrio. Estos dispositivos confinan vapores de metales alcalinos en cavidades microfabricadas y son una plataforma prometedora para aplicaciones de fotónica integrada. La fabricación se basa en dos técnicas: el *Optical Contact Bonding*, proceso sin adhesivo que une superficies mediante fuerzas intermoleculares, y la microfabricación por láser de femtosegundo, que crea microestructuras 3D en el interior del vidrio. Ambas se complementan con tratamientos químicos, de plasma, térmicos y de presión. La caracterización incluye inspección visual mediante anillos de Newton, medición de energía de unión por el método de doble viga en voladizo, ensayos de tracción, análisis nanométrico por microscopía de fuerza atómica y pruebas de fugas por espectroscopía. Las aplicaciones exploradas incluyen magnetoencefalografía, relojes atómicos, instrumentación espacial e inspección de corrosión en vías de tren. Experimentos de magnetometría demuestran la detección de resonancia Hanle en una celda de vapor de cesio.

Palabras clave: Celdas de Vapor Escritas por Láser; Microfabricación por Láser de Femtosegundo; Unión por Contacto Óptico; Vapor de Metal Alcalino; MEMS; Fotónica Integrada; Activación de Superficies; Tratamiento de Plasma; Sensores Atómicos; Magnetometría; Resonancia Hanle; Magnetoencefalografía; Relojes Atómicos; Espectroscopía de Absorción; Hermeticidad al Helio; Microscopía de Fuerza Atómica; Proceso FLICE; Unión a Baja Temperatura

Resum

Aquest Treball de Fi de Màster presenta un estudi sobre el disseny, la fabricació i la caracterització de cel·les de vapor escrites per làser (LWVCs), sensors atòmics miniaturitzats completament de vidre. Aquests dispositius confinen vapors de metalls alcalins en cavitats microfabricades i constitueixen una plataforma prometedora per a aplicacions de fotònica integrada. La fabricació es basa en dues tècniques: l'*Optical Contact Bonding*, procés sense adhesiu que uneix superfícies mitjançant forces intermoleculars, i la microfabricació per làser de femtosegon, que crea microestructures 3D a l'interior del vidre. Ambdues es complementen amb tractaments químics, de plasma, tèrmics i de pressió. La caracterització inclou inspecció visual mitjançant anells de Newton, mesura d'energia d'unió pel mètode de doble biga en voladís, assajos de tracció, anàlisi nanomètrica per microscòpia de força atòmica i proves de fuites per espectroscòpia. Les aplicacions explorades inclouen magnetoencefalografia, rellotges atòmics, instrumentació espacial i inspecció de corrosió en vies de tren. Experiments de magnetometria demostren la detecció de la ressonància Hanle en una cel·la de vapor de cesi.

Paraules clau: Cel·les de Vapor Escrites per Làser; Microfabricació per Làser de Femtosegon; Unió per Contacte Òptic; Vapor de Metall Alcalí; MEMS; Fotònica Integrada; Activació de Superfícies; Tractament de Plasma; Sensors Atòmics; Magnetometria; Ressonància Hanle; Magnetoencefalografia; Rellotges Atòmics; Espectroscòpia d'Absorció; Hermeticitat enfront de l'Heli; Microscòpia de Força Atòmica; Procés FLICE; Unió a Baixa Temperatura

Abstract

This Master's thesis presents a study on the design, fabrication, and characterization of Laser-Written Vapor Cells (LWVCs), a novel class of miniaturized all-glass atomic sensors. These devices confine alkali metal vapors in micro-machined cavities and are promising platforms for integrated photonics applications. Fabrication relies on two core techniques: Optical Contact Bonding, a glueless process joining glass surfaces through intermolecular forces, and Femtosecond Laser Micromachining, which creates buried 3D microstructures inside glass using ultrashort laser pulses. Both are complemented by chemical, plasma, thermal, and pressure treatments. Characterization methods include visual inspection via Newton's rings, bonding energy measurements using the double cantilever beam method, tensile strength testing, sub-nanometric surface analysis via Atomic Force Microscopy, and a spectroscopy-based leak test protocol. Applications explored include magnetoencephalography, atomic clocks, space instrumentation, and rail corrosion inspection. Preliminary magnetometry experiments demonstrate Hanle resonance detection in a cesium vapor cell, validating the potential of LWVCs as compact, high-performance atomic sensors.

Keywords: Laser-Written Vapor Cells; Femtosecond Laser Micromachining; Optical Contact Bonding; Alkali Metal Vapor; MEMS; Integrated Photonics; Surface Activation; Plasma Treatment; Atomic Sensors; Magnetometry; Hanle Resonance; Magnetoencephalography; Atomic Clocks; Absorption Spectroscopy; Helium Hermeticity; Atomic Force Microscopy; FLICE Process; Low-Temperature Bonding

” ¡Bien, riámonos porque Don Quijote toma a los molinos por gigantes! ¡Bien, Don Quijote no debió ver un gigante donde había un molino! Pero, ¿por qué el hombre sabe de gigantes? ¿Dónde hay o ha habido gigantes? Mas, si no los hay ni los ha habido, resulta que no Don Quijote, sino el hombre, la especie humana en algún momento de su historia descubrió un gigante donde no lo había”.

– Antonio Machado, Juan de Mairena.

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List of Abbreviations

AFM Atomic Force Microscopy.

FLICE Femtosecond Laser Induced Chemical Etching.

FLW Femtosecond Laser Writing.

FWHM Full Width Half Maximum.

HWP Half Wave Plate.

LWVC Laser-Written Vapor Cell.

MEMS Micro-electromechanical systems.

NEG Non-evaporable Getter.

PBS Polarizing Beam Splitter.

QWP Quarter Wave Plate.

RIE Reactive Ion Etching.

RMS Root Mean Square.

TTV Total Thickness Variation.

Part I

Thesis

Chapter 1

Introduction & Motivation

Chapter 2

Design of Vapor Cells

2.1 Initial Considerations & Constraints

2.2 General Design of Individual LWVCs

2.3 Wafer-Level Approach

2.4 Real Examples

Chapter 3

Fabrication Methods

Precision miniaturized sensors have become an increasingly relevant technology over recent decades, finding applications in navigation, medical diagnostics, geophysical surveying, and fundamental physics research [1]. The growing demand for compact, high-performance devices has driven the development of new fabrication techniques capable of producing smaller, more complex geometries while maintaining extreme gas purity, free of contaminants that could degrade sensor performance. Manufacturing such devices is inherently challenging: the internal cavities must be hermetically sealed to prevent outgassing or contamination, the interaction volume must be precisely defined to ensure reproducibility, and the cell must accommodate optical access from multiple directions to support the beam geometries required by techniques such as multipass cells, dual-beam, or cavity-enhanced sensing [1]. Traditional fabrication strategies, such as MEMS-based anodic bonding, offer excellent scalability but are fundamentally limited to planar geometries and restricted optical access. Photolithographic approaches, while capable of producing nanostructured vapor cells, share the same limitation of planar bonding strategies [2].

A Laser-Written Vapor Cell (LWVC) addresses these limitations by exploiting the three-dimensional structuring capabilities of Femtosecond Laser Writing (FLW), enabling arbitrary buried geometries within a monolithic transparent substrate [1]. The complete fabrication workflow is illustrated in Fig. 3.1 and consists of four main steps, each of which contributes to the precision and hermeticity of the final device, as described below and discussed in detail in the following sections.

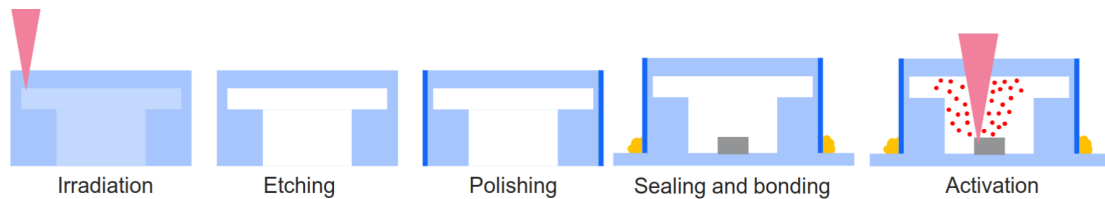


Figure 3.1: Fabrication workflow of a Laser-Written Vapor Cell. Steps (1-2) describe the FLICE process. In step (4) NEG dispenser placement and bonding are performed. Activation is illustrated by step (5). From [1].

Step 1: Femtosecond Laser Writing and Chemical Etching (FLICE)

The first step employs the so-called FLICE technique (Femtosecond Laser Irradiation followed by Chemical Etching), a two-stage maskless microfabrication process [1]. An ultrafast laser beam is tightly focused inside the bulk of a fused silica substrate, inducing the local formation of self-oriented nanogratings through nonlinear absorption. Because the material modification is confined to the laser focal spot, arbitrary three-dimensional patterns can be inscribed with micrometric resolution and without any lithographic mask. In the second stage, the substrate is immersed in a hydrofluoric acid solution, which selectively removes the irradiated material, leaving behind hollow channels and reservoirs with the desired geometry. The non-irradiated fused silica remains unaffected, preserving the monolithic integrity of the substrate and its broad optical transparency window—a key advantage for spectroscopic characterization of the gas content. This maskless approach enables geometries that are inaccessible to planar bonding or photolithographic techniques, including fully buried sensing channels and multi-sided optical access. The FLICE process and its optimization for LWVC fabrication are further discussed in Section 3.1.

Step 2: Placement of the Non-Evaporable Getter Dispenser

Once the internal cavities have been formed, a pill of non-evaporable getter (NEG) material is placed inside the reservoir cavity of the fused silica structure [1]. NEG materials serve a dual function: upon thermal activation, they simultaneously release the alkali metal vapor required for atomic sensing, and absorb residual buffer gases such as nitrogen. This dual action enables the production of cells with sub-atmospheric buffer gas pressures without the need for a vacuum apparatus, greatly simplifying the manufacturing process while maintaining the gas purity essential for high-precision applications. The ability to control the buffer gas pressure post-sealing—by adjusting the duration of getter heating or by pre-filling with controlled fractions of ungetterable gases such as argon—offers an additional degree of freedom for optimizing sensor performance [1].

Step 3: Sealing and Bonding

After the dispenser has been placed, the cell must be hermetically sealed to prevent contamination and ensure long-term stability. The sealing is performed inside a controlled-atmosphere chamber filled with nitrogen containing very low amounts of O_2 , thereby preventing the trapping of reactive oxygen inside the cell [1]. The choice of bonding method is critical, as it directly affects hermeticity, thermal stability, and compatibility with the cell's optical coatings and internal components.

Bonding glass and crystal presents unique engineering challenges due to the material's non-porous nature, extreme smoothness, and high surface energy. In industrial applications, selecting the right adhesive or process is critical for ensuring optical clarity, structural integrity, and durability against environmental factors. Some of the most common glass bonding methods are:

- **UV-Curing Adhesives:** These are one-component resins that remain liquid until exposed to specific wavelengths of ultraviolet light. Upon UV exposure, a rapid polymerization process begins. This method offers strong, precise, and optically transparent joints, since the refractive index of the adhesive can be tuned to match that of the substrate [3].
- **Anodic Bonding:** The substrates are heated to 300°C – 500°C while a high voltage ($\approx 1\text{ kV}$)

is applied. Ions in the glass migrate, creating a space-charge region that generates a strong electrostatic attraction, resulting in a permanent chemical bond [4].

- **Laser Microwelding:** A focused laser locally melts and fuses the glass substrates at the interface, creating a bond without the need for intermediate adhesive layers or high global temperatures [5].

While these methods are widely used, they present specific challenges in the context of MEMS and vapor cell manufacturing. Adhesives at the bonding interface can migrate into the sealed cavity and contaminate the gas, critically affecting the performance of high-precision devices such as atomic clocks [6]. Furthermore, adhesives may overheat upon interaction with high-power lasers during subsequent processing or operation steps, inducing mechanical stress, birefringence, thermal expansion, and crack formation [7]. Adhesive-based bonds also typically fail to meet the hermeticity standards required for demanding applications [8]. Adhesive-free methods such as anodic bonding, while achieving excellent hermeticity, require elevated global temperatures [4], which increases the risk of thermally induced stress and renders them incompatible with temperature-sensitive optical coatings [9].

A modern solution that can address all of these challenges simultaneously is *Optical Contact Bonding* [10], which achieves a hermetic, adhesive-free joint at room temperature through van der Waals and hydrogen-bond interactions between two ultra-flat, clean surfaces. This method is fully compatible with the FLICE-based LWVC fabrication process and is discussed in detail in Section 3.2.

Step 4: Getter Activation

In the final step, the sealed cell is exposed to a focused laser beam directed at the NEG dispenser through the fused silica substrate. The laser locally heats the dispenser, triggering the release of rubidium vapor into the sensing chamber and the simultaneous absorption of residual buffer gas [1]. Because the activation is performed optically and post-sealing, the cell does not need to be re-opened or placed in a vacuum system, preserving hermeticity throughout the entire process. The precise control of activation time and laser power allows the residual buffer gas pressure to be tuned, directly influencing key sensing parameters such as the spin coherence time and pressure-induced spectral broadening. The activation procedure and its effects on cell performance are discussed in Section 3.3.2.

3.1 Femtosecond Laser Micromachining

MILLORAR

The fabrication of vapor cells and other precision optical devices requires the controlled removal of glass to create internal cavities, channels, and complex three-dimensional structures. This task is non-trivial: glass is simultaneously transparent, brittle, and highly chemically resistant, which means that conventional machining approaches often fail to meet the precision and surface quality standards demanded by atomic sensing applications [11].

Mechanical machining with diamond-tipped tools or ultrasonic drilling is effective at the macro-scale but introduces micro-cracks and residual internal stress that can lead to structural failure in thin substrates [11]. Wet chemical etching with hydrofluoric acid (HF) is isotropic, meaning it

attacks the material equally in all directions, making it difficult to produce deep channels with high aspect ratios or well-defined geometries. Dry plasma-based techniques such as Reactive Ion Etching (RIE) offer greater directionality but are restricted to surface patterns due to their extremely slow volumetric etch rates [12]. Critically, none of these methods allows for the fabrication of fully *buried* three-dimensional structures within a monolithic substrate, which is precisely the capability required by Laser-Written Vapor Cells.

3.1.1 Femtosecond Laser Writing

Femtosecond Laser Writing (FLW) overcomes all of the above limitations by exploiting the non-linear optical response of transparent materials to ultrashort laser pulses. Glass is nominally transparent to visible and near-infrared light; however, when a femtosecond pulse (duration $\sim 10^{-15}$ s) is tightly focused inside the bulk of a glass substrate, the instantaneous intensity at the focal spot ($\sim 10^{13}$ – 10^{14} W/cm²) becomes sufficient to trigger multiphoton and tunnel ionization processes [11]. Energy is deposited exclusively within the focal volume through these nonlinear mechanisms, leaving the surrounding material and the glass surface unaffected. This enables the inscription of arbitrary three-dimensional patterns deep inside the substrate simply by scanning the focal spot along the desired trajectory.

A key advantage of femtosecond pulses over longer-pulse or continuous-wave lasers is the absence of a significant heat-affected zone (HAZ). Because the pulse duration is shorter than the characteristic thermal diffusion time of the material ($\sim$ ps–ns), energy is deposited before heat can propagate to the surroundings [11, 12]. The process is therefore considered *cold machining*: it induces permanent structural modification at the focal point without melting, burr formation, or thermal cracking in the adjacent glass. Depending on the irradiation parameters—pulse energy, repetition rate, scan velocity, and numerical aperture—the nature of the modification can range from a smooth refractive index change, suitable for waveguide inscription, to the formation of self-organized nanoscale gratings (nanogratings), which are exploited in the FLICE process described below [13].

3.1.2 The FLICE Technique

Femtosecond Laser Irradiation followed by Chemical Etching (FLICE) is a two-step microfabrication process that combines the three-dimensional structuring capability of FLW with the material selectivity of wet chemical etching, allowing the fabrication of hollow microstructures buried inside a transparent substrate [14, 15].

In the first step, the femtosecond laser is scanned along the surfaces delimiting the desired hollow volume. Under appropriate irradiation conditions, the deposited energy induces the formation of self-oriented nanogratings within the focal volume [16]. These nanogratings consist of periodic nanoscale planes of modified material aligned perpendicularly to the laser polarization direction, and they significantly increase the chemical reactivity of the irradiated glass with respect to the surrounding unmodified bulk. In the second step, the substrate is immersed in an etchant solution—typically hydrofluoric acid (HF) or potassium hydroxide (KOH)—which dissolves the laser-modified material at a rate 100 times faster than the pristine glass [12]. The result is a smooth, hollow structure with the geometry defined by the laser scan, while the rest of the substrate remains intact and monolithic.

The orientation of the laser polarization plays a critical role in determining the etching efficiency.

Because nanogratings align parallel to the laser polarization, orienting the polarization perpendicular to the longitudinal axis of an elongated channel results in nanogratings aligned along the channel direction, which favors acid penetration and increases the effective etching speed along that axis [1]. For complex multi-component geometries, the polarization direction must therefore be selected carefully for each sub-component in order to synchronize the etching rates across the entire structure and ensure complete and uniform material removal [1].

3.1.3 Application to Laser-Written Vapor Cells

The fabrication of the LWVC reported by Lucivero et al. [1] demonstrates the direct application of FLICE to the production of alkali-metal vapor cells in fused silica. The irradiation step was performed using a commercial femtosecond laser source emitting 300 fs pulses at 520 nm with a pulse energy of 410 nJ and a repetition rate of 1 MHz, focused inside a $10 \times 10 \times 5$ mm fused silica block using a $50\times$ microscope objective with numerical aperture 0.6 [1]. The irradiated geometry, displayed in Fig. 3.2, consisted of a cylindrical reservoir (5 mm diameter, 3.5 mm height) connected to a rectangular parallelepiped sensing channel (1×1 mm cross-section, 9.5 mm length).

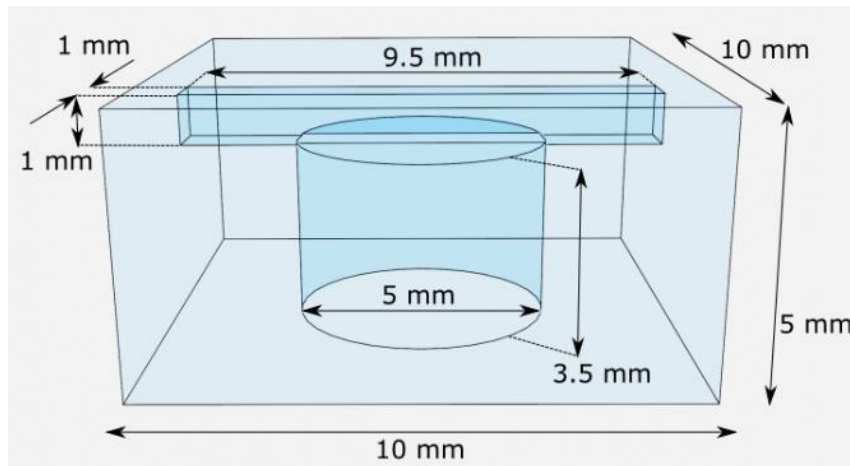


Figure 3.2: Laser-Written Vapor Cell manufactured using the FLICE technique. It consists of a cylindrical reservoir (5 mm diameter, 3.5 mm height) connected to a rectangular parallelepiped sensing channel (1×1 mm cross-section, 9.5 mm length). From [1]

Chemical etching was subsequently performed in a 20% aqueous HF solution at 35°C for approximately 18 hours, after which the sensing chamber was left buried at approximately $300\ \mu\text{m}$ below the top surface of the substrate [1]. This stand-off distance could in principle be reduced to a few tens of micrometers, enabling near-field sensing geometries with sub-millimeter proximity to an external sample. The inner surfaces of the etched structure present a residual roughness in the range 50–100 nm RMS, which introduces optical scattering losses of approximately 8% per facet [17]. This roughness can be substantially reduced, down to 20 nm RMS, by performing a thermal annealing step after etching [18], which also partially relaxes residual stress in the glass.

The maskless and direct-write nature of FLICE makes it particularly well suited to rapid prototyping: new cell geometries can be implemented without any change of lithographic mask or process chemistry. Furthermore, since the entire cell is carved from a single monolithic substrate, there are no bonded interfaces inside the sensing volume, eliminating a potential source of outgassing

or contamination. These properties, combined with the compatibility of fused silica with anti-relaxation coatings and with waveguide inscription by the same laser system, make FLICE the enabling technology for the LWVC platform [1, 13].

3.2 Optical Contact Bonding

Optical contact bonding is a glueless joining process in which two closely conformal surfaces adhere purely through intermolecular forces, without the need for adhesives or intermediate layers [19]. This property makes it particularly attractive for the hermetic sealing of Laser-Written Vapor Cells and other glass-based atomic sensors, where outgassing from adhesives, thermal incompatibility, or optical absorption at the bond interface can compromise device performance [20].

Intermolecular forces are, in isolation, insufficient to create a robust bond between two substrates. However, when mating surfaces conform to each other with nanometric precision, the resulting *intimate contact* over a sufficiently large area produces intermolecular interactions with a measurable macroscopic effect [21]. The bonding process can be understood through an energy balance: a bond front propagates across the interface if and only if the reduction in surface energy associated with the newly formed contact exceeds the elastic strain energy that must be stored in the wafers as they deform to accommodate each other's surface deviations [22, 23, 24]. For a surface gap of height h and lateral extent R on a wafer of thickness t and Young's modulus E , the bonding criterion takes the approximate form

$$\gamma \gtrsim C \frac{E t^3 h^2}{R^4}, \quad (3.1)$$

where γ is the work of adhesion per unit area and C is a geometry-dependent numerical prefactor [22, 23]. In practice, this imposes strict roughness and waviness requirements on both surfaces [19]. When these requirements are met and appropriate surface treatments are applied, bonding energies comparable to that of the bulk material (2.5 J m^{-2}) can be achieved [25].

Achieving such bond strengths requires a carefully sequenced preparation protocol. The following sections describe the key elements of this protocol: material selection and surface quality requirements, chemical treatment, plasma treatment, annealing, and mechanical pressure assistance. Each step builds on the previous one; together, they determine the final bond quality and make optical contact bonding a viable low-temperature process for LWVC fabrication [26].

3.2.1 Types of Glasses & Quality Requirements

The success of optical contact bonding critically depends on both the material properties of the glass substrates and their surface quality. Different glass types exhibit distinct chemical compositions, thermal characteristics, and mechanical behaviors that directly influence bonding performance. This section examines the most commonly employed glasses and establishes the surface quality requirements necessary for achieving robust, void-free bonds.

Fused Silica and Quartz Fused silica (SiO_2 , amorphous) and quartz (SiO_2 , crystalline) represent the gold standard for optical contact bonding. As characterized by Brückner [27], these materials offer several key advantages:

- **High purity and homogeneity:** Ultra-high purity grades ($>99.99\%$ SiO_2) minimize contamination and ensure uniform bonding behavior across the interface.
- **Low thermal expansion coefficient:** With a CTE of approximately $0.5 \times 10^{-6} \text{ K}^{-1}$, fused silica undergoes minimal dimensional changes, thereby reducing thermal stress at the interface.
- **Excellent optical transmission:** High transparency from UV to IR wavelengths (200 nm to 2500 nm) [28].
- **Chemical inertness:** Resistance to most acids and organic solvents permits aggressive cleaning treatments without substrate degradation.
- **High damage threshold:** Superior resistance to laser-induced damage makes these materials suitable for high-power systems [29].

The primary distinction between fused silica and quartz lies in their structural organization: fused silica is amorphous and isotropic, while quartz is crystalline and exhibits optical anisotropy [27]. For most bonding applications—and in particular for LWVCs—synthetic fused silica is preferred due to its isotropic properties and the exceptional surface quality achievable through polishing [30].

Borosilicate Glasses Borosilicate glasses, particularly Borofloat 33 (81% SiO_2 , 13% B_2O_3 , 4% $\text{Na}_2\text{O}/\text{K}_2\text{O}$, 2% Al_2O_3), have gained widespread adoption in MEMS fabrication and vacuum cell manufacturing [31, 24]:

- **Moderate thermal expansion:** A CTE of approximately $3.25 \times 10^{-6} \text{ K}^{-1}$ [32] is compatible with silicon ($2.6 \times 10^{-6} \text{ K}^{-1}$), making this glass suitable for glass-to-silicon bonding [10].
- **Good chemical resistance:** Adequate resistance to standard cleaning treatments, though less robust than fused silica [31].
- **Cost-effectiveness:** Significantly lower cost compared to fused silica while maintaining sufficient optical quality for many applications.
- **Commercial availability:** Readily available in wafer formats with polished surfaces meeting bonding requirements.

Other Optical Glasses Several specialized glass families address niche requirements. Aluminosilicate glasses offer higher mechanical strength, improved thermal shock resistance [33], and lower permeation rates for certain gases—such as helium—which is particularly relevant for LWVC hermeticity [34, 35]. Ultra-low-expansion glasses such as Zerodur, with CTE values near zero, are indispensable in applications demanding extreme dimensional stability, including space telescopes and lithography systems [36].

Surface Quality Requirements The bonding criterion in Eq. (3.1) directly motivates the surface quality thresholds summarized in Table 3.1. For a given material—with fixed E , t , and γ —the criterion sets an upper bound on the tolerable gap amplitude h as a function of its lateral scale R . Three parameters are most critical in practice:

1. **Surface Roughness:** RMS roughness below 0.5 nm and peak-to-valley roughness below 2 nm over the bonding area [10] are required to ensure intimate contact and allow intermolecular forces to dominate. At these length scales the gap amplitude h is sufficiently small that even short lateral extents R satisfy Eq. (3.1). Furthermore, the bonding energy is proportional to the real area of contact, which decreases with increasing roughness independently of whether the surfaces close at the macroscale [37].
2. **Flatness and Waviness:** Total thickness variation (TTV) must remain below 1 μm for 100 mm diameter wafers. Surface flatness must be better than $\lambda/10$ (approximately 60 nm at 633 nm) for precision optical applications. Intermediate-scale waviness is particularly detrimental: its lateral extent R is not large enough for the R^4 denominator in Eq. (3.1) to suppress the elastic energy cost, yet its amplitude h can reach tens of nanometres—far exceeding that of fine surface roughness [25, 38].
3. **Particulate Contamination:** Bonding must be performed under cleanroom conditions (Class 100 or better, ISO 5). Even sub-micron particles can nucleate localized voids that propagate across the interface; surface particle counts must therefore be minimized, with particular attention to particles larger than 0.1 μm [39].

Table 3.1: Surface quality requirements for optical contact bonding.

Parameter	Requirement	Reference
RMS roughness	$< 0.5 \text{ nm}$	[10]
Peak-to-valley roughness	$< 2 \text{ nm}$	[10]
TTV (100 mm wafer)	$< 1 \mu\text{m}$	[10]
Flatness (clear aperture)	$< \lambda/10 \approx 60 \text{ nm}$	[25]
Min. particle size	$< 0.1 \mu\text{m}$	[39]
Cleanroom class	ISO 5 (Class 100)	[39]

Meeting these geometric requirements is necessary but not sufficient for bonding success. Even polished surfaces that satisfy all roughness and flatness criteria above retain organic contaminants, metallic impurities, and an insufficient density of reactive surface groups. Chemical treatment addresses these molecular-scale obstacles, as described in the following section.

3.2.2 Chemical Treatment

Chemical treatment pursues two distinct but complementary objectives. The first is *cleaning*: removing organic matter, metallic ions, and particulate contamination that would prevent intimate contact regardless of how well the surface geometry has been prepared. The second is *activation*: maximising the density of reactive silanol groups (Si-OH) at the surface, which serve as the molecular precursors to the interfacial hydrogen bonds formed upon contact and the covalent siloxane bridges formed during annealing [19]. In practice, both objectives are addressed by the same sequence of chemical baths, but they operate through distinct mechanisms that are worth understanding separately.

Chemical Cleaning

Solvents. The cleaning sequence begins with mechanical degreasing using organic solvents. Acetone dissolves fats, waxes, and photoresist residues [40]. Ethanol follows as a miscible rinse: it removes residual acetone without leaving ionic residues, and its high volatility ensures rapid, streak-free evaporation. These steps reduce the organic load before the substrates enter the more aggressive chemical baths, which are expensive and whose lifetime is shortened by excessive organic contamination.

Piranha Solution ($\text{H}_2\text{SO}_4:\text{H}_2\text{O}_2$, 3:1). The primary wet-chemical agent for stubborn organic removal is Piranha solution, a strongly exothermic mixture that operates through two concurrent mechanisms at different rates. The first and faster mechanism is dehydration: concentrated H_2SO_4 strips hydrogen and oxygen from organic molecules as water, exploiting the highly favourable enthalpy of hydration ($\Delta H \approx -880 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$). This process carbonises organic residues within seconds, reducing them to water-soluble fragments [41]. The second, slower mechanism is oxidation: as described in Figure 3.3, H_2SO_4 reacts with H_2O_2 to form Caro's acid (H_2SO_5), a potent oxidising agent that generates hydroxyl radicals capable of breaking C–H and Si–O bonds alike [42]. The net effect on the glass surface is twofold: organic contaminants are eliminated, and the oxidising radicals attack the outermost Si–O–Si (siloxane) bonds, cleaving them and leaving the exposed silicon atoms terminated as Si–OH groups. Piranha therefore acts simultaneously as a cleaner and as a hydroxylating agent, and substrates emerge from the bath with a highly hydrophilic, silanol-rich surface, such as the one displayed in Figure 3.4.

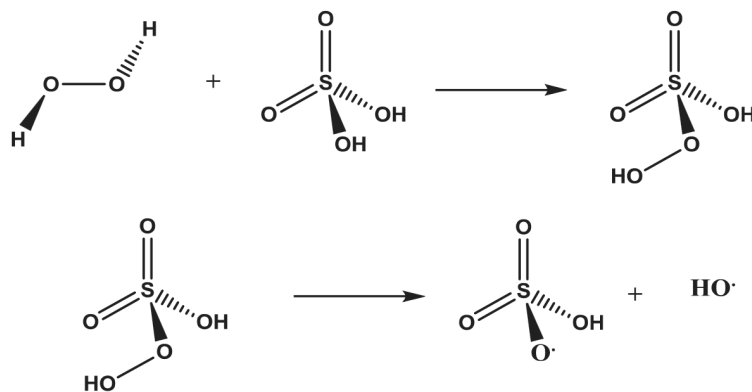


Figure 3.3: Hydroxyl radicals formation upon the decomposition of Caro's acid in Piranha solution. From [43].

RCA-1 ($\text{NH}_4\text{OH}:\text{H}_2\text{O}_2:\text{H}_2\text{O}$, 1:1:5 at 70–80 °C). The RCA Standard Clean 1 (SC-1), introduced by Kern and Puotinen in 1970 [44], targets light organic films and, most importantly, sub-micron particulate contamination. Its mechanism relies on a dynamic oxide dissolution–regeneration cycle: in the alkaline environment maintained by NH_4OH , the H_2O_2 simultaneously oxidises the outermost silica layer to form a thin chemical oxide, while the NH_4OH dissolves this oxide at approximately the same rate [42]. This cycle continuously regenerates the surface, and the key consequence for particle removal is mechanical: as the oxide beneath an adhered particle is dis-

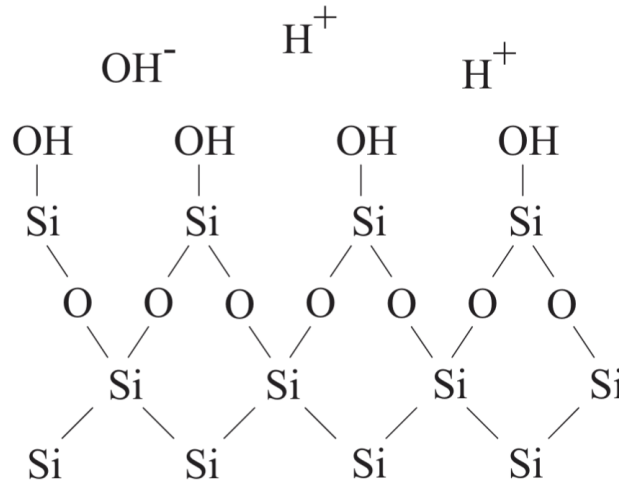


Figure 3.4: Schematic representation of a hydroxylated/hydrophilic surface. From [42].

solved away, the particle becomes undercut and loses its mechanical anchorage to the substrate, leaving it free to diffuse into solution. At the basic pH of SC-1, both the oxidised glass surface and the surfaces of most particle contaminants acquire a negative Zeta potential (as displayed in Figure 3.5), creating an electrostatic repulsion that prevents re-deposition once particles are dislodged [42]. The repeated oxidation–dissolution cycles also leave the surface with a dense, freshly formed termination of Si-OH groups, contributing to surface activation. Additionally, the NH_4OH also serves to remove some metals such as Cu, Au, Ag, Zn, and Cd, and some elements from other groups such as Ni, Co, and Cr [42].

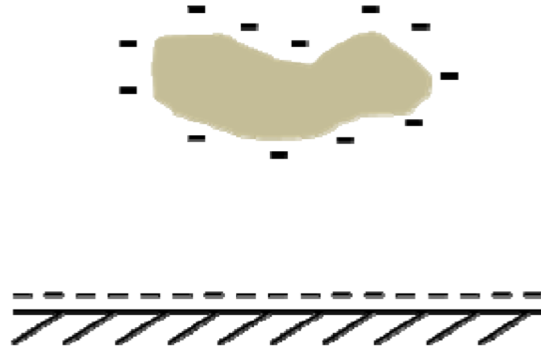


Figure 3.5: Schematic representation of a contaminant being lifted from a quartz surface due to the Zeta potential. Adapted from [45].

RCA-2 ($\text{HCl}:\text{H}_2\text{O}_2:\text{H}_2\text{O}$, 1:1:6 at 70 °C). The second RCA step (SC-2) targets metallic contamination introduced either during previous processing or by the SC-1 bath itself, which can deposit trace metal ions onto the surface. Its mechanism is straightforward: H_2O_2 oxidises metallic species to their ionic forms, while HCl provides a strongly acidic environment in which these ions form soluble chloride complexes that are rinsed away with the bath [44, 42]. The acidic pH also reverses

the Zeta potential of the surface, which is advantageous for removing metal hydroxide colloids that might have survived SC-1. SC-2 has no significant activation effect on the silanol density.

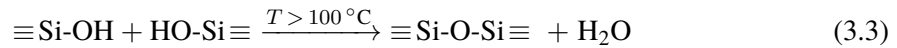
Ultrasonic Agitation. For all bath steps, ultrasonic agitation substantially enhances contaminant removal. High-frequency sound waves generate microscopic cavitation bubbles in the liquid; their violent implosion near the glass surface produces localised pressure jets that dislodge particles from recesses and pores that are otherwise inaccessible to chemical soaking alone [46].

Chemical Activation

The cleaning steps described above increase surface hydrophilicity as a side effect of their primary cleaning action. Dedicated activation takes this further. A hydroxylated silica surface exposed to ambient humidity rapidly adsorbs water molecules onto its Si-OH sites, building up a chemisorbed water layer one to a few monolayers thick [47]. When two such surfaces are brought into contact, this water layer bridges the opposing silanol groups through a network of hydrogen bonds [19]:



This water-mediated hydrogen-bonding network provides the initial room-temperature adhesion required to handle the bonded pair. As the interface is annealed at temperatures above $\sim 100^\circ\text{C}$, the water is gradually expelled and adjacent silanol pairs condense directly into covalent siloxane bridges [48, 49]:



The bond energy after annealing scales with the number of siloxane bridges formed per unit area, which in turn is limited by the silanol density present at the time of contact [48, 47]. Since no treatment after bonding can introduce new silanol groups at the buried interface, the activation state achieved before contact is an upper bound on the final bond strength.

The most widely used activation step is an additional SC-1 soak applied immediately before bonding. The dissolution–regeneration cycle described above continuously exposes fresh, uncontaminated silica with a maximum density of Si-OH groups estimated at approximately 4.6 nm^{-2} on a fully hydroxylated amorphous silica surface [47]. In practice, a water contact angle below 5° after the final DI water rinse is used as the operational criterion for successful activation, as it indicates that the silanol density is sufficient for spontaneous bonding upon contact [10, 24]. An alternative activation method is exposing the substrates to a *plasma treatment*, as explained in Section 3.2.3.

3.2.3 Plasma Treatment

Plasma treatment unifies the cleaning and activation functions described above into a single process, while adding a third benefit unavailable through wet chemistry alone: the enhancement of interfacial water and gas diffusivity. Together, these three mechanisms make plasma treatment one of the most impactful steps in the bonding protocol, capable of yielding high bonding energies even at low annealing temperatures. In a plasma cleaner, a mixture of electrons, ions, free radicals, and photons acts simultaneously on the glass surface [19, 50, 51], as illustrated in Figure 3.6:

1. **Removal of surface contaminants:** Plasma decomposes and volatilizes organic matter, producing additional dangling bonds and increasing the fraction of bonded area [53, 54].

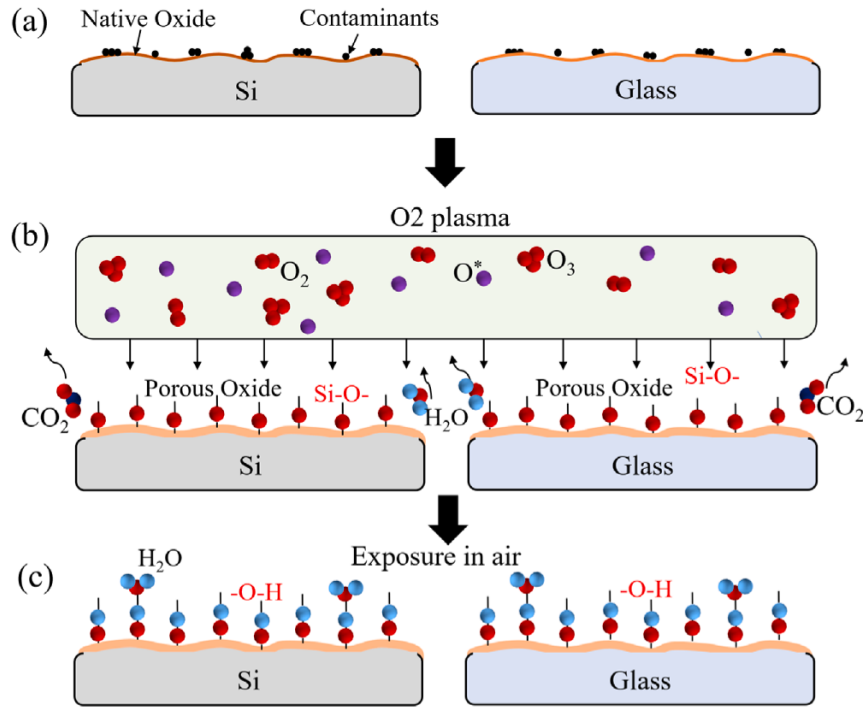


Figure 3.6: Effects of plasma treatment on silica surfaces. Plasma removes contaminants and increases the density of available silanol groups. Adapted from [52].

2. **Increase in silanol group density:** Plasma-induced surface modification raises the concentration of silanol groups (Si-OH), which are directly correlated with bonding strength [19].
3. **Enhancement of interfacial diffusivity:** Plasma treatment increases the diffusivity of water and trapped gas at the interface [51]. Water evacuation promotes the conversion of weak, reversible hydrogen bonds into stronger Si-O-Si covalent bonds, while gas removal prevents bubble formation during annealing.

Common process gases include O₂, N₂, and Ar [51, 54]. Plasma power, chamber pressure, gas flow rate, and exposure time must all be carefully controlled, since overexposure increases surface roughness and degrades bond quality.

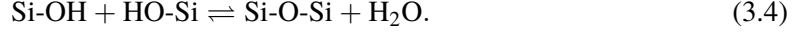
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A critical procedural constraint is that plasma treatment must always follow all chemical cleaning or activation steps: subsequent exposure to chemicals can etch the activated surface and negate the benefits of the treatment [55]. Conversely, brief exposure to deionized water (DIW) or ambient air after plasma treatment is beneficial, since water molecules attach to the Si-O⁻ groups and convert them into silanol groups [52]. The recommended workflow is therefore: (1) chemical cleaning, (2) chemical activation (e.g., RCA-1), (3) plasma treatment, (4) DIW rinse, and (5) pre-bonding and annealing.

Plasma treatment is especially valuable for low-temperature optical contact bonding in LWVCs: it produces bond energies exceeding 1 J m^{-2} at annealing temperatures as low as 100°C [49, 52], well below the thresholds that would damage pre-structured glass components.

3.2.4 Thermal Treatment

When two sufficiently flat and clean glass surfaces are brought into contact, the bonding process initiates through the formation of hydrogen bonds between opposing silanol groups [56]. These bonds can subsequently be converted into permanent covalent siloxane bonds via the condensation reaction:



For this reaction to proceed irreversibly, water must be removed from the interface [19]. This is accomplished through *annealing*: baking the bonded assembly in a controlled thermal environment. The three parameters governing the outcome are the temperature ramp, the equilibrium temperature, and the annealing time.

The *temperature ramp* (heating rate) must be kept as low as possible. Rapid temperature increases induce differential thermal stresses in the glass substrates that can compromise mechanical and optical performance, or cause

The *equilibrium temperature* controls water diffusivity at the interface: higher temperatures accelerate moisture removal and promote viscous flow, which increases surface conformity [19]. However, elevated temperatures are incompatible with precision devices that incorporate optical coatings, pre-structured channels, or integrated electronics [26]. In such cases—including LWVCs, where laser-written microstructures must be preserved—plasma activation is essential, as it raises surface energy and water diffusivity sufficiently to achieve strong bonds at temperatures as low as 100 °C [53]. This approach is referred to as *Low-Temperature Direct Bonding*.

Regarding *annealing time*, bond energy increases monotonically following a logarithmic trend, whether through dedicated annealing or through prolonged room-temperature contact [53]:

$$\gamma \propto \ln\left(\frac{t}{\mu}\right), \quad (3.5)$$

where t is the annealing time and μ is a temperature-dependent time constant. Annealing effectively reduces μ , allowing maximum bond energy to be reached orders of magnitude faster than at room temperature. Typical annealing durations for optical applications range from 2 to 24 hours [53, 52, 26, 24, 57], as illustrated in Figure 3.7.

3.2.5 Pressure Treatment

Applied mechanical pressure during the bonding phase can promote intimate contact by elastically deforming surface asperities and closing residual gaps at the interface [58, 57], as illustrated in Figure 3.8. This mechanical assistance is particularly relevant for wafers with insufficient flatness, where the van der Waals attraction alone cannot provide enough energy to close macroscopic gaps [22, 25]. In those cases, the bonding condition can be understood through an energy balance: bonding propagates when the reduction in surface energy associated with the newly formed interface exceeds the elastic strain energy stored in the deformed wafers. External pressure shifts this balance in favor of bonding by forcing asperities into contact [22, 38].

For well-polished, optically flat wafers, however, the role of pressure is more ambiguous. Since the bonding energy at room temperature is governed primarily by the real area of contact—which is in turn dictated by surface roughness at the nanoscale rather than by externally applied load—additional mechanical pressure does not necessarily increase the intrinsic bond energy [37, 59].

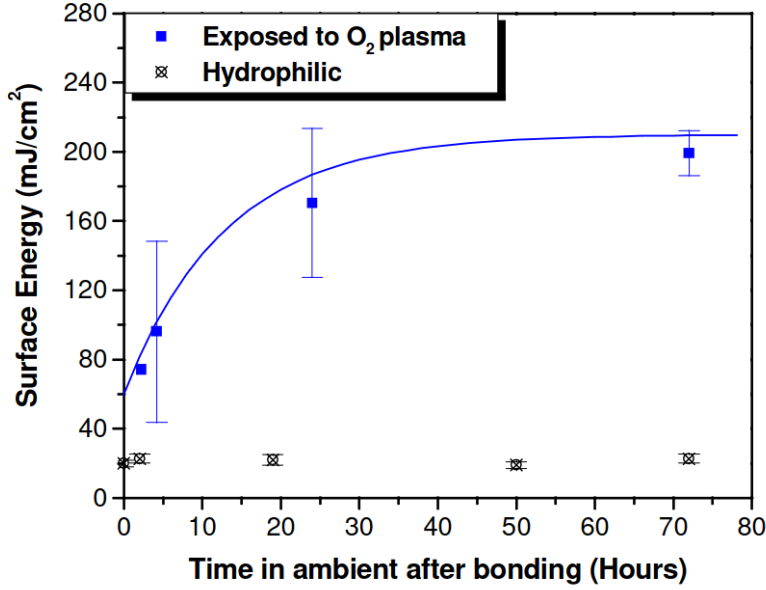


Figure 3.7: Evolution of bonding energy with annealing time. Bond strength follows a logarithmic growth law; annealing reduces the characteristic time constant μ , accelerating convergence toward the bulk fracture energy. From [53].

In this regime, the spontaneous van der Waals or hydrogen-bonding forces are already sufficient to bring the surfaces into full intimate contact, and the bond energy is ultimately limited by the surface chemistry and the density of interfacial bonds, not by the mechanical load. This is consistent with the classical observation that optically contacted surfaces adhere spontaneously without any applied force [24]. External pressure is therefore best understood as a means of extending the range of acceptable wafer flatness rather than as a mechanism for strengthening an already well-formed bond.

Pressure magnitude must nonetheless be optimized carefully, regardless of wafer quality. Research on Borofloat 33 wafers demonstrates that a load of 0.07 MPa maximizes flexural strength; pressures beyond this threshold introduce stress concentrations that cause premature failure [57]. Non-uniform pressure distributions pose additional risks: stress-induced birefringence and permanent wavefront distortion can compromise optical performance in precision devices [60, 61]. High-precision applications therefore require well-planarized pressure plates with peak-to-valley flatness on the order of micrometers, fabricated from stiff materials such as technical ceramics [62].

Birckigt et al. [62] describe a setup in which convex and concave pressure plates—with waviness of 5 μm and 3 μm , respectively—promote radially outward propagation of the contact front during the initial bonding phase (Figure 3.9). This geometry mitigates the risk of void entrapment and introduces radially symmetric residual stresses that are more predictable and manageable than those arising from asymmetric loading. A key insight from this work is that the geometry and flatness of the pressure plates affect the contact-front dynamics independently of the magnitude of the applied load, underscoring that pressure uniformity is often more critical than pressure magnitude.

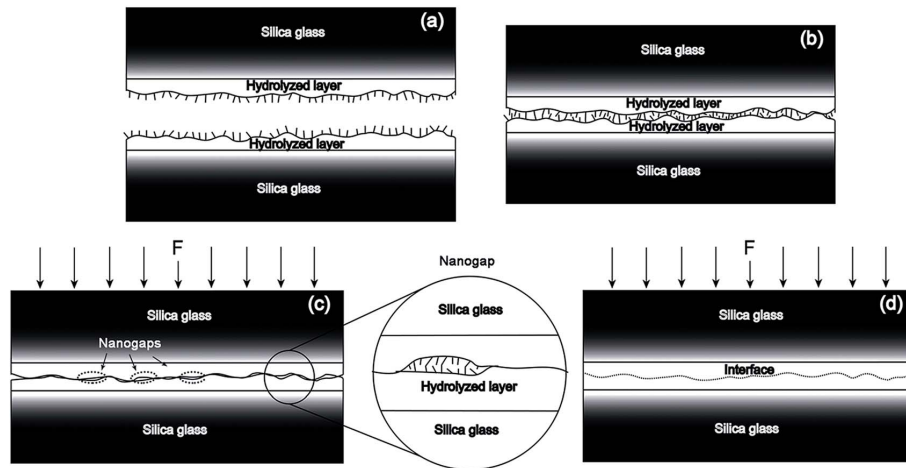


Figure 3.8: Effect of applied pressure on the bonding process. Forces perpendicular to the interface suppress void formation by closing residual gaps between surface asperities. From [58].

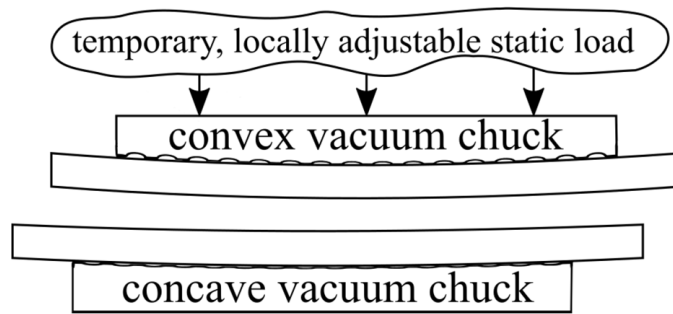


Figure 3.9: Pressure plate geometry described by Birckigt et al. [62]. The curved profiles guide contact front propagation outward from the center, reducing the probability of interface void formation.

3.3 Post-Treatment

3.3.1 Enhanced Helium Hermeticity

Helium plays a critical role in the operation of various atomic sensors, serving primarily as a working medium or buffer gas in high-sensitivity applications (e.g., magnetoencephalography [63]). However, due to its extremely small atomic radius, helium exhibits one of the highest permeation rates through glass walls compared to other gases and alkali metals typically confined within micro-electromechanical systems (MEMS) vapor cells.

For high-precision applications where long-term cell hermeticity is paramount, aluminum oxide (Al_2O_3 , or alumina) has been identified as a highly effective barrier [34, 35]. Researchers have found that utilizing aluminosilicate glass—a glass matrix enriched with Al_2O_3 —or depositing thin Al_2O_3 coatings directly onto standard glass cells significantly mitigates helium diffusion.

As illustrated in Figure 3.10, the permeability constant (K) of aluminosilicate glass is between

two and three orders of magnitude lower than that of conventional borosilicate glass. Furthermore, applying an Al_2O_3 coating to borosilicate cells can independently reduce helium permeability by one to two orders of magnitude. Synergistically combining an aluminosilicate glass substrate with the aforementioned Al_2O_3 coating yields the best results, achieving ultra-low permeabilities on the order of $10^{-22} \text{ m}^2\text{s}^{-1}\text{Pa}^{-1}$.

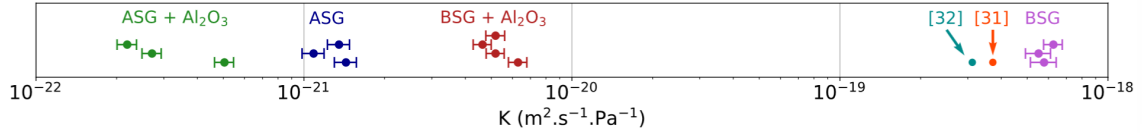


Figure 3.10: Comparison of the permeability constant K across uncoated borofloat, uncoated aluminosilicate, Al_2O_3 -coated borofloat, and Al_2O_3 -coated aluminosilicate glasses. From [34].

3.3.2 Activation

3.4 Step-by-Step Experimental Procedure

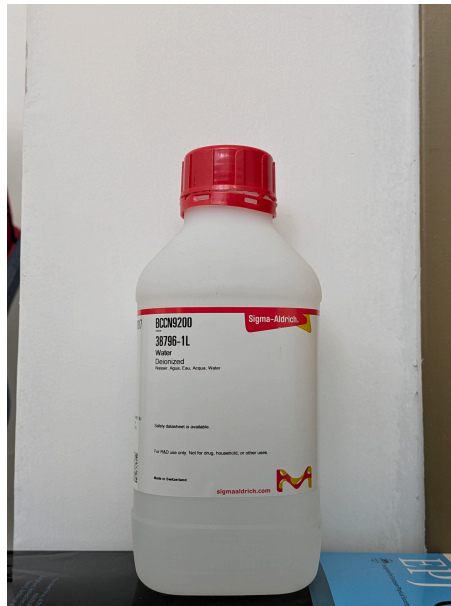


Figure 3.11: DIW

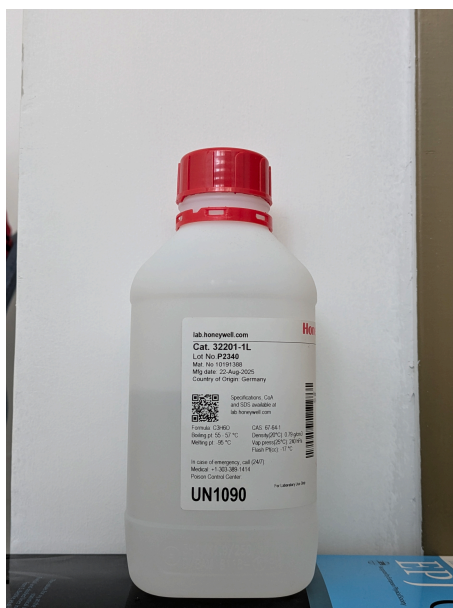


Figure 3.12: Acetone

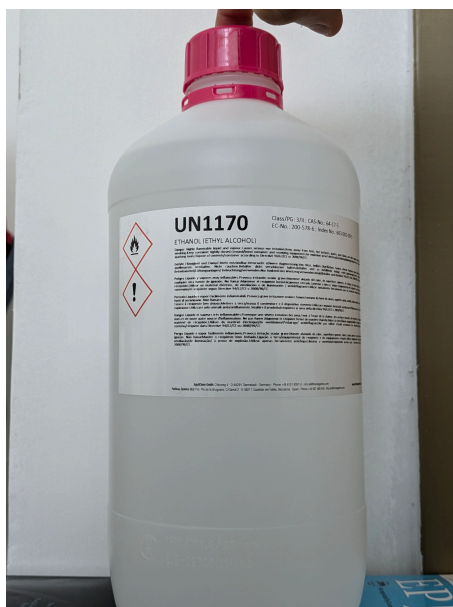


Figure 3.13: Ethanol

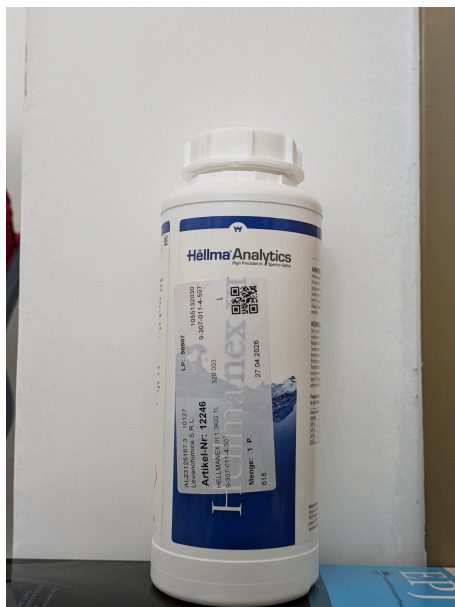


Figure 3.14: Soap

Chapter 4

Characterization and Quality Control

Ensuring excellent quality standards throughout the fabrication process is a fundamental requirement in the development of atomic sensors based on alkali vapor cells. The performance of such devices depends critically on several interdependent physical properties of the fabricated components, ranging from the nanometric quality of the glass surfaces to the mechanical integrity of the bonded interfaces and the long-term hermeticity of the sealed cell. Consequently, a rigorous characterization and quality-control framework must accompany each stage of the fabrication pipeline, from the initial substrate preparation through to the final sealed device.

Pre-bonding Characterization

Before any bonding attempt is made, the substrate surfaces must be thoroughly characterized to ensure they meet the stringent requirements of low-temperature bonding techniques such as Optical Contact Bonding. Two complementary methods are employed at this stage. First, Atomic Force Microscopy (AFM) is used to inspect the surface topography at the sub-nanometric scale, yielding quantitative roughness parameters over representative areas of the sample. This allows both the as-received substrate quality to be verified against manufacturer specifications and the effect of surface treatments—such as cleaning or plasma activation—to be assessed. Second, contact angle measurements provide a direct and experimentally simple assessment of surface hydrophilicity: a low water contact angle indicates a highly hydroxylated surface, which is a prerequisite for strong and defect-free hydrophilic bonding. Together, these two techniques establish whether a substrate is ready for bonding, and provide a baseline against which post-process surfaces can be compared.

Post-bonding Characterization

Once bonding has been performed, the focus shifts to evaluating the integrity of the newly formed interface and, ultimately, of the complete sealed device. As a first non-destructive step, visual inspection based on thin-film interference (Newton's rings) reveals the presence of macroscopic defects, trapped particles, or surface flatness deviations at the bonding interface, providing immediate qualitative feedback on the bonding outcome. When a quantitative assessment is required, two complementary mechanical tests are employed: the *Double Cantilever Beam* (DCB) method, also known as the razor blade or blade insertion test, which quantifies the interfacial energy release rate G by measuring crack propagation length; and the tensile (pull) test, which directly measures the bonding strength in terms of the critical stress σ_C required to fracture the interface.

Finally, once the cell has been sealed and activated with the alkali metal vapor, the stability and purity of the internal gas environment must be carefully monitored over time. Any compromise in hermeticity—allowing atmospheric gases to permeate the sealed cavity—would degrade sensor performance through unwanted pressure broadening and frequency shifts of the atomic transitions. Laser absorption spectroscopy, exploiting the pressure dependence of the Lorentzian linewidth and line-center shift of the alkali D-line transitions, provides a non-invasive and highly sensitive method for quantifying the internal gas pressure and for establishing meaningful upper bounds on the leak rate.

This section presents in detail the theoretical framework and experimental procedures underlying each of these characterization techniques, and reports the results obtained during the quality assessment of the vapor cells fabricated in this work.

4.1 Surface inspection using an Atomic Force Microscope

Atomic Force Microscopy (AFM) is a sophisticated type of scanning probe microscopy, which consists of a physical probe that scans the specimen in order to produce images of surfaces. Atomic Force Microscopes can map the topology of a surface with sub-nanometric resolution, which makes them an ideal tool for surface inspection in the context of atomic sensors, and more specifically in the context of Optical Contact Bonding, due to the strict glass roughness requirements of this method. The experimental characterization presented in this work was carried out using the facili-

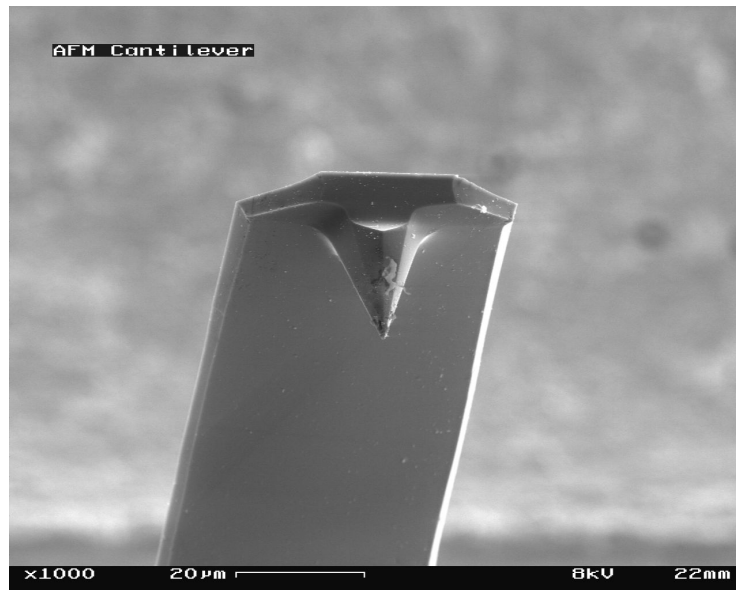


Figure 4.1: Example of the probe of an Atomic Force Microscope. From [64].

ties of the Physics Department at the *Politecnico di Bari* (POLIBA) in Bari, Italy.

A brand-new Nanoquartz glass disk, with a specified Root Mean Square (RMS) roughness of 500 pm and a Total Thickness Variation (TTV) of 2 µm, was inspected using a Park NX10 AFM. The measurements were performed with a Park Scout 350 tip in *tapping* mode (resonance frequency 320 kHz, scan rate 0.5 Hz). We examined the sample in three different spots of its surface to ensure consistency. The obtained data was subsequently analyzed using the *Gwyddion* software,

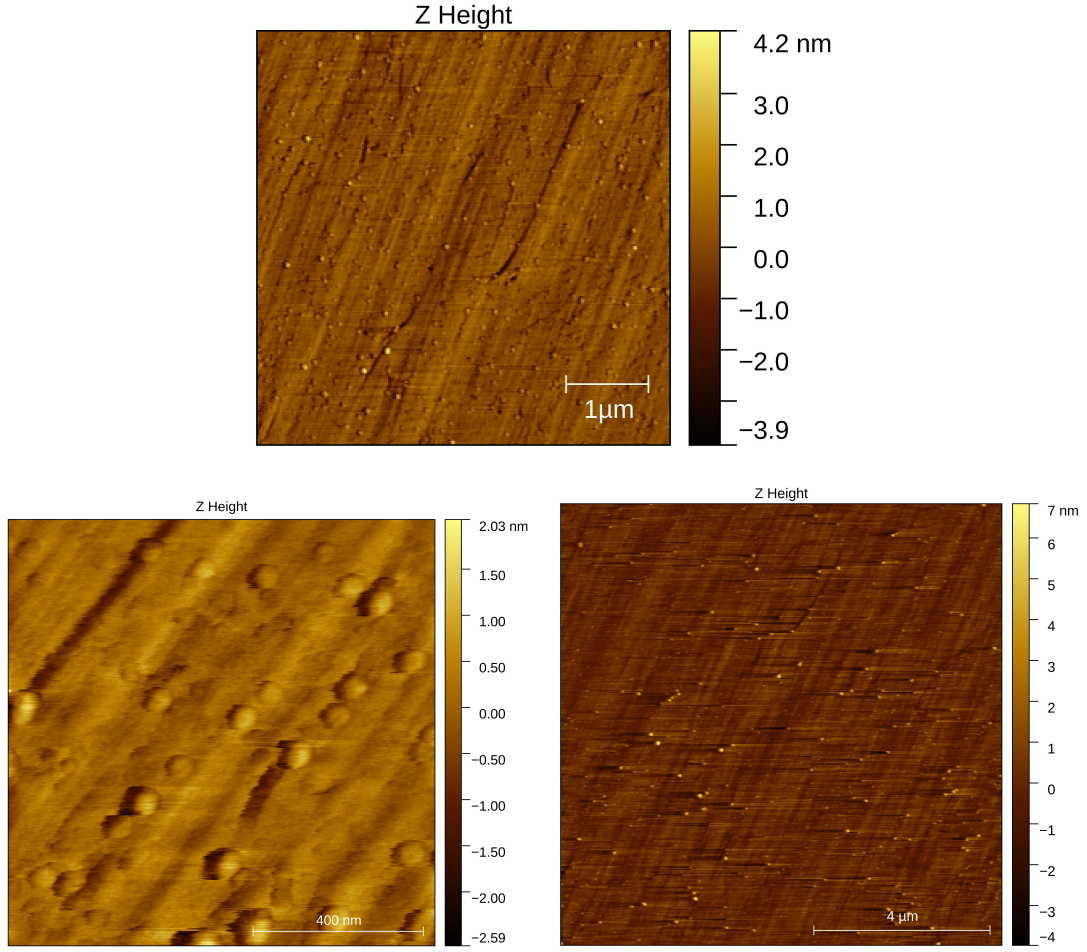


Figure 4.2: 2D Surface images obtained through AFM in three different parts of the pristine Nanoquartz disk's surface.

through which we obtained the two-dimensional (Figure 4.2) and three-dimensional (Figure 4.3) images. The resulting density distribution of roughness is displayed in Figure 4.4, and the detailed list of the surface parameters estimated from our measurements can be found in Table 4.1. The precise definition of these parameters is provided in [65].

The results confirm that the Root Mean Square roughness of the disk is around 500 pm, as suggested by the manufacturer. An alternative estimation of the surface roughness, known as *Mean roughness* (S_a) was found to be in the same order of magnitude. Additionally, it was determined that the total height (S_q) is in the range of a few nanometers. The mean height is approximately zero, suggesting that the surface's defects are uniformly distributed. The outstanding surface parameters observed in this disk comply with Optical Contact Bonding requirements and therefore it is suitable for the fabrication of Laser-Written Vapor Cells and high-precision atomic sensors.

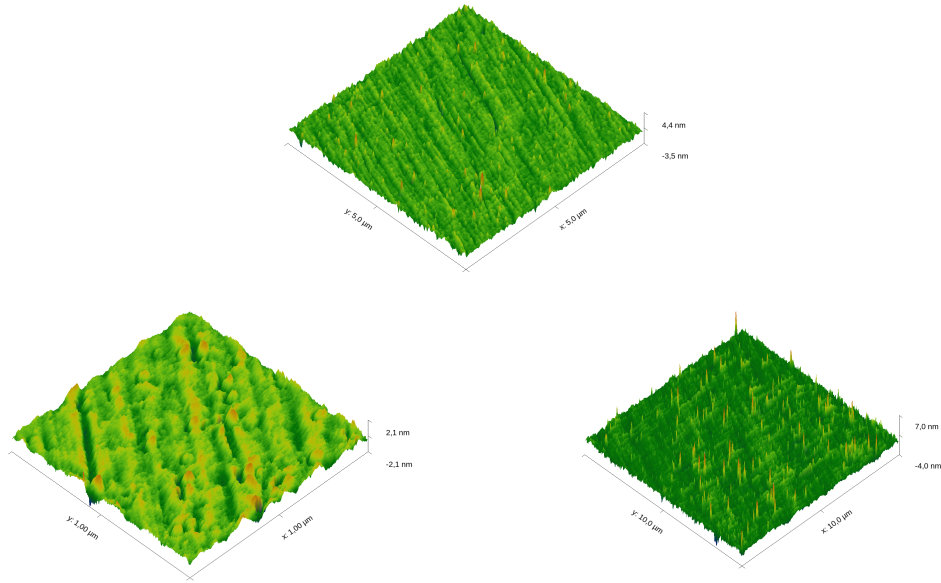


Figure 4.3: 3D Surface images obtained through AFM in three different parts of the pristine Nanoquartz disk's surface.

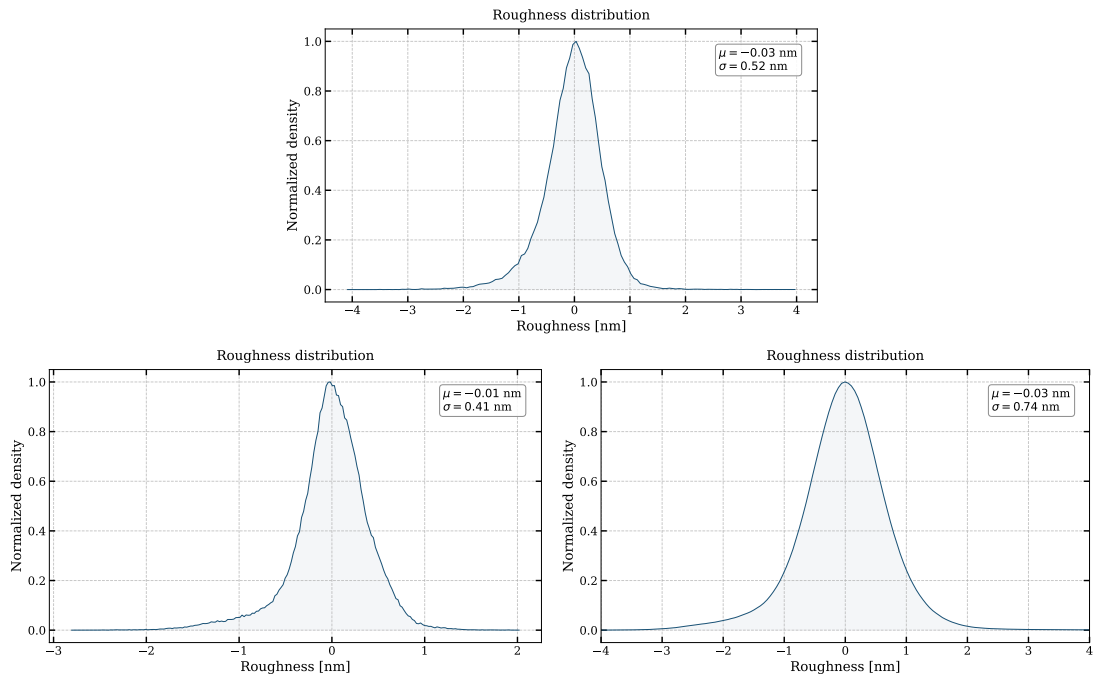


Figure 4.4: Surface roughness distribution obtained through AFM. It can be seen that most of the defects are below the 1 nm range. Furthermore, the mean (μ) is close to zero, confirming that the surface is uniform.

Sample	S_q [pm]	S_a [pm]	S_p [nm]	S_v [nm]	S_z [nm]	Mean height [nm]
1	518	387	4.02	-4.14	8.17	0.03
2	411	298	2.04	2.83	4.87	0.02
3	726	529	7.66	4.05	11.71	0.02

Table 4.1: Surface parameters obtained through AFM in three different parts of the surface: Root mean square roughness (S_q), Mean roughness (S_a), Maximum peak height (S_p), Minimum valley depth (S_v), Maximum height (S_z) and Mean height

4.2 Contact Angle Measurement

The water contact angle (WCA) is the standard characterization method used in the optical contact bonding literature to assess the chemical state of a glass surface prior to bonding [10, 24]. In this simple method, the measured angle is a direct proxy for the density of reactive surface groups that govern bond formation.

The contact angle θ_C is geometrically defined as the angle formed at the three-phase boundary where a liquid droplet, the surrounding gas, and the solid substrate meet simultaneously, as illustrated in Figure 4.5. At mechanical equilibrium, the angle satisfies Young's equation [66]:

$$\cos \theta_C = \frac{\gamma_{sg} - \gamma_{sl}}{\gamma_{lg}}, \quad (4.1)$$

where γ_{sg} , γ_{sl} , and γ_{lg} denote the solid–gas, solid–liquid, and liquid–gas interfacial energies, respectively. This equation expresses the condition that minimises the total free energy of the system for a virtual displacement of the contact line [66]: the contact angle is determined entirely by the balance between the tendency of the liquid to spread over the solid (governed by $\gamma_{sg} - \gamma_{sl}$) and the tendency of the liquid–gas interface to contract (governed by γ_{lg}). As γ_{sg} increases relative to γ_{sl} , the liquid spreads more, and θ_C decreases.

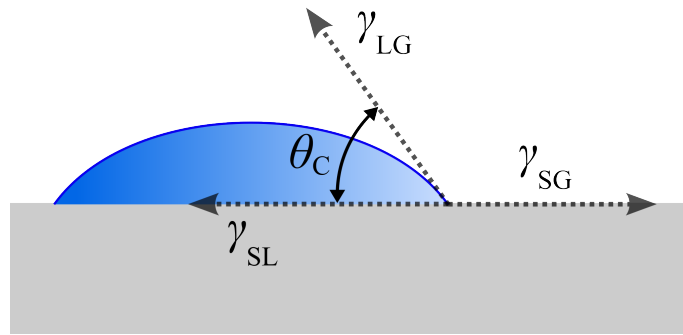


Figure 4.5: Geometrical definition of the contact angle θ_C at the three-phase boundary between a liquid droplet, the ambient gas, and the solid substrate. The equilibrium value is set by the balance of interfacial energies expressed in Young's equation (Eq. (4.1)). From [67].

On silica and glass surfaces, the magnitude of γ_{sg} is controlled by the density of surface hydroxyl groups, commonly referred to as silanol groups (Si-OH). Silanol groups are simultaneously hydrogen-bond donors and acceptors [47], which gives them a strong chemical affinity for water.

A fully hydroxylated silica surface therefore exhibits a very high γ_{sg} and a low γ_{sl} , resulting in low contact angles. As the silanol density decreases, whether due to thermal treatment, which converts Si-OH groups into hydrophobic siloxane bridges (Si-O-Si), or due to organic contamination, which physically blocks hydrophilic sites, γ_{sg} falls and γ_{sl} rises. By Young's equation, this directly translates into an increase in θ_C . The WCA thus provides an experimentally accessible measurement of the silanol surface density, without requiring the use of more complex or expensive techniques.

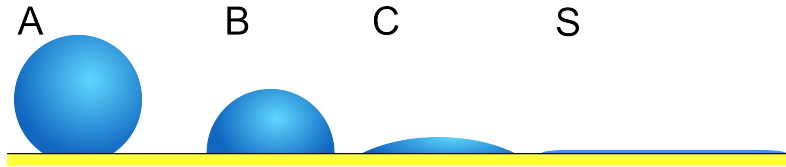


Figure 4.6: Representative contact angle regimes across different wettability states. Surface A ($\theta_C > 90^\circ$) is hydrophobic; surfaces B, C, and D are sorted from partially to fully hydrophilic ($\theta_C \rightarrow 0^\circ$). From [68].

The connection between the WCA and optical contact bonding is therefore direct: the silanol groups whose density is encoded in the contact angle are the same reactive sites that initiate bond formation. A low WCA is therefore not merely a qualitative indicator of surface cleanliness, but a quantitative predictor of the maximum achievable bond energy. For this reason, a contact angle below $\sim 5^\circ$ is consistently used as the pass/fail threshold for surface activation in the direct bonding literature [10, 24].

4.3 Visual Inspection

Visual inspection is a primary, non-destructive method for evaluating the integrity of optical contact bonds. The physical principle underlying this technique is thin-film interference, which manifests visibly as Newton's rings when the contacting surfaces are illuminated.

In an ideal optical contact bonding process, the interfacial air gap is completely eliminated. Optically, this results in the disappearance of interference fringes, indicating a defect-free and continuous bond. However, the presence of Newton's rings during or after the bonding process serves as a direct indicator of interfacial defects. These interference patterns occur due to localized variations in the gap thickness between the two surfaces. Issues can be identified and evaluated through this phenomenon are trapped air and voids, particulate contamination and surface flatness deviations [69, 19]. Figure 4.7 shows an example of Newton rings.

Depending on the optical properties of the materials involved, visual inspection is conducted using different setups. For transparent optical components, monochromatic or white light interferometry is typically used. Conversely, for materials that are opaque in the visible spectrum, such as silicon wafers, infrared (IR) transmission imaging is routinely employed to visualize these interference patterns at the bonding interface [50]. Ultimately, an interfacial region completely devoid of visible Newton's rings serves as the standard criterion for a successful, defect-free optical contact bond.

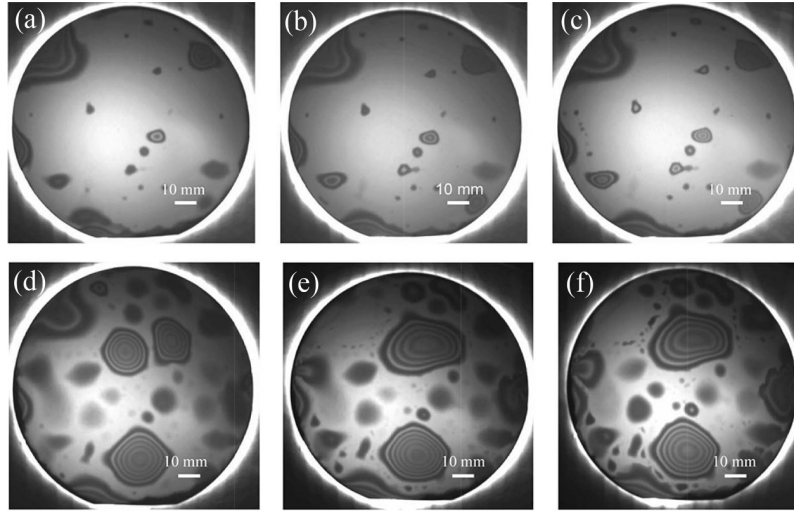


Figure 4.7: Examples of Newton rings formed in the interphase of Si/Si wafers. From [70].

4.4 Bonding Energy Test

The most widely employed technique for measuring wafer bonding strength is the *double cantilever beam* (DCB) method, also known as the blade insertion test, crack opening test, or Maszara's method [71]. It consists of inserting a thin blade or razor (typically 0.1 mm thick) into the bonding interface, which induces crack propagation along the bonded wafer pair [71]. This setup is illustrated in Figure 4.8. The bonding strength is quantified in terms of the energy release rate G (in J m^{-2}), which represents the surface energy required to create new surfaces during crack propagation. This parameter can also be expressed as surface energy γ , where $G = 2\gamma$ for symmetric fracture.

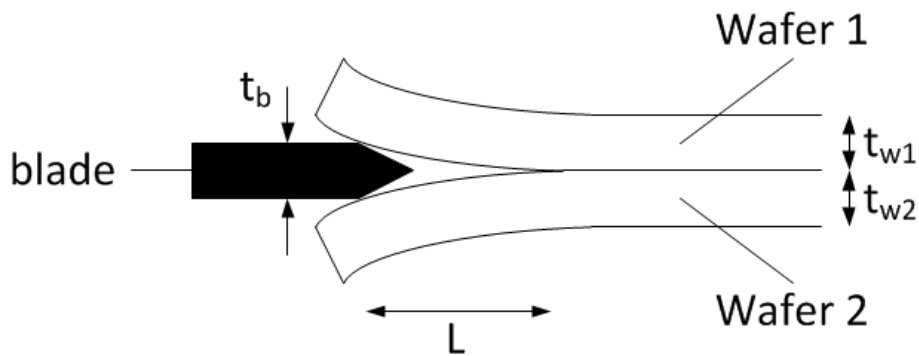


Figure 4.8: Illustration of the razor blade method. A razor blade is inserted between the bonded surfaces in order to quantify the bonding energy between them. From [72].

Theoretical Framework The energy release rate is calculated based on the energy balance between the elastic strain energy stored in the deformed substrates and the surface energy of the newly created surfaces during crack propagation. For bonded wafers with potentially different materials and thicknesses, the energy release rate is given by [71]:

$$G = \frac{3t^2 E_1 E_2 h_1^3 h_2^3}{8L^2 (E_1 h_1^3 + E_2 h_2^3)} \quad (4.2)$$

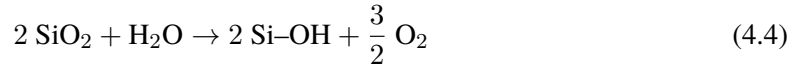
where t is the blade thickness, E_1 and E_2 are the Young's moduli of the substrates, h_1 and h_2 are the substrate thicknesses, and L is the crack length measured from the blade insertion point. For identical substrates ($E_1 = E_2 = E$ and $h_1 = h_2 = h$), this expression simplifies to:

$$G = \frac{3t^2 E h^3}{8L^2} = \frac{3t^2 E}{32y^2} \quad (4.3)$$

where $y = L/(2h)$ is the normalized crack length.

Experimental Procedure and Considerations The DCB measurement requires careful attention to several experimental parameters. First, crack length observation should be performed after a sufficient waiting period (typically 210 s) following blade insertion to avoid the effects of static fatigue at the bonding interface [71]. For transparent substrates, crack propagation can be observed optically; for opaque materials such as silicon, infrared imaging or acoustic microscopy is necessary.

Water Stress Corrosion Effects A critical consideration in bonding strength measurement, particularly for Si-based materials, is the effect of *water stress corrosion*. This phenomenon occurs when Si–O–Si bonds under applied stress react with water molecules according to the reaction [73]:



This water-assisted bond breakage significantly lowers the measured fracture toughness of SiO_2 structures, with reductions of up to 50% observed in wet atmospheres compared to dry conditions [73].

Controlled Atmosphere Measurements Recent advances have enabled the separation of water stress corrosion effects from ambient water and interfacial residual water through measurements under controlled atmospheres [71]. By performing DCB tests under three distinct conditions—wet atmosphere (ambient air with 50–70% relative humidity), dry atmosphere (pure N_2 gas), and vacuum ($\sim 3 \times 10^{-3}$ Pa)—the individual contributions can be isolated.

Figure 4.9 illustrates the water stress corrosion mechanism under different measurement atmospheres. In wet atmosphere, ambient water molecules attack the Si–O–Si bonds at the crack tip, reducing the measured bonding strength. In dry atmosphere, only residual interfacial water (trapped during low-temperature bonding) contributes to stress corrosion. Under vacuum conditions, interfacial water is partially desorbed as the crack propagates, minimizing the corrosion effect and yielding the highest measured bond strength [71].

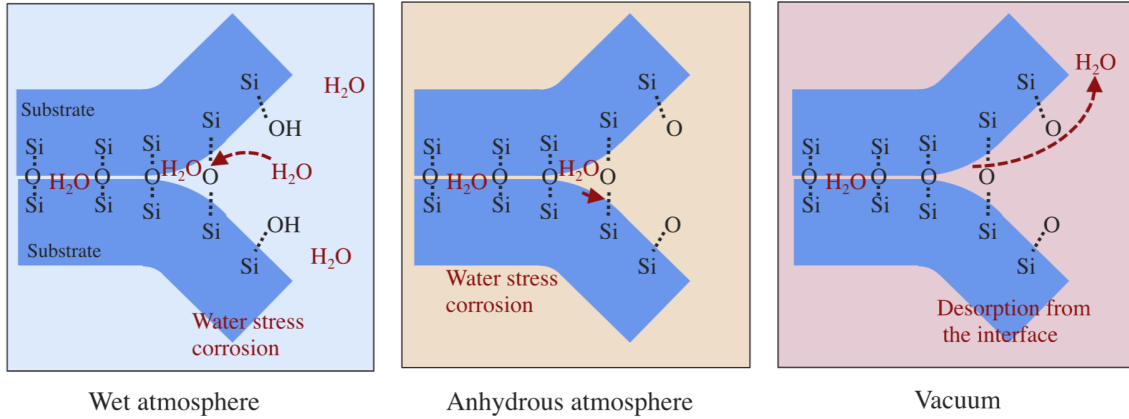


Figure 4.9: Schematic representation of water stress corrosion at the hydrophilic bonding interface during debonding under controlled atmospheres. Left: wet atmosphere showing ambient water attack on Si–O–Si bonds. Center: anhydrous (dry) atmosphere with reduced water availability. Right: vacuum conditions with partial desorption of interfacial water. Adapted from [71].

Advantages and Limitations The DCB method offers several important advantages: experimental simplicity requiring minimal equipment, direct measurement of surface energy, and applicability to full wafer-level bonding without the need for dicing into smaller specimens [71]. The technique is particularly valuable for process development and quality control in low-temperature bonding applications. However, several limitations must be considered:

- **Measurement range:** The method is limited to bond strengths lower than the intrinsic surface energy of the substrates, typically below $2\text{--}3 \text{ J m}^{-2}$ for most Si-based materials [71].
- **Atmospheric sensitivity:** Results are strongly influenced by measurement atmosphere, with variations up to 50% between wet and dry conditions for SiO_2 -based interfaces [73].
- **Edge effects and stress concentrations:** Crack initiation at wafer edges can introduce measurement artifacts.

4.5 Bonding Strength Test

One of the most widely used methods to assess bonding strength is the *tensile test* (also known as the pull test or direct tensile method). In this approach, bonded substrates are attached to two separate fixtures using a high-strength adhesive. These fixtures are then pulled apart in a direction perpendicular to the bonding interface, applying tensile stress that tends to separate the bonded wafers. A typical experimental setup is shown in Figure 4.10 [74, 75].

Fracture Mechanics Analysis Assuming that the bonding strength is lower than the adhesive's strength, cracks will be produced at the bonding interface when a certain strength threshold is exceeded. The fracture behavior can be characterized using linear elastic fracture mechanics (LEFM).

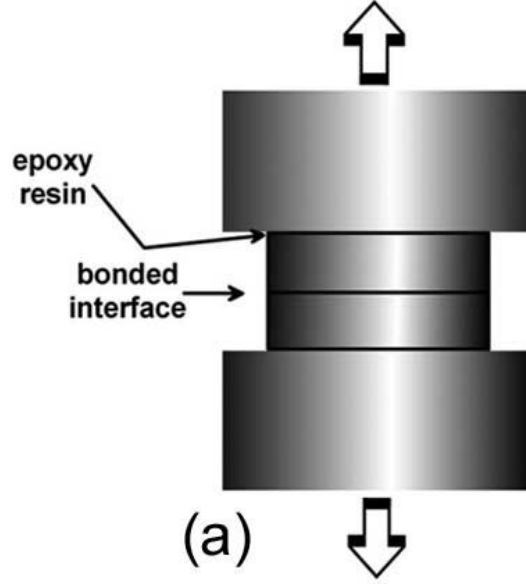


Figure 4.10: Schematic diagram of the tensile test setup for bonding strength measurement. The bonded wafer pair is glued to metal fixtures and subjected to perpendicular tensile force. Adapted from [10].

Depending on the crack length, a *stress intensity factor* (K_I) can be estimated using the following expression [74, 10]:

$$K_I = \sigma Y \left(\frac{a}{\omega} \right) \sqrt{\pi a} \quad (4.5)$$

where a is the crack length, σ is the applied stress, and ω is the substrate width. The dimensionless parameter $Y \left(\frac{a}{\omega} \right)$ is a geometric correction factor that accounts for the finite geometry of the wafer and the crack position. For standard edge cracks (the most common failure mode), $Y \approx 1.12$ [76]. For internal cracks located far from the edge, $Y \approx 1.0$ [76].

Crack Propagation Criterion Cracks will propagate along the interface—and therefore cause complete fracture—if the stress intensity factor exceeds the material’s fracture toughness limit ($K_I > K_{IC}$). This critical value often depends on several parameters, including the crystallographic orientation of the material, temperature, loading rate, and environmental conditions [74, 77].

For brittle materials under mode I loading (tensile opening), the fracture toughness can be theoretically estimated in terms of the surface energy (γ) as [10]:

$$K_{IC} = \sqrt{\frac{2E\gamma}{(1-\nu^2)}} \quad (4.6)$$

where E is the Young’s modulus and ν is the Poisson ratio of the material.

From Equations 4.5 and 4.6, a critical stress (σ_C) for crack propagation can be derived:

$$\sigma_C = \sqrt{\frac{2E\gamma}{Y^2 \left(\frac{a}{\omega}\right) \pi a(1 - \nu^2)}} \quad (4.7)$$

This critical stress represents the bonding strength that can be experimentally measured.

Advantages and Limitations The tensile test offers several advantages, including experimental simplicity, direct measurement of bonding strength, and straightforward interpretation based on well-established fracture mechanics principles [75]. However, several limitations must be considered:

- **High measurement variance:** Real experiments exhibit significant scatter in bonding strength values, which can be attributed to local variations in surface parameters such as roughness, total thickness variation (TTV), particle contamination, and bonding defects [75, 10].
- **Edge effects:** Stress concentrations at wafer edges can lead to premature failure that does not accurately represent the average bonding quality [74].
- **Adhesive influence:** The test results may be affected by the properties of the adhesive used to attach the fixtures, particularly if the adhesive fails before the bond [75].
- **Sample preparation:** Careful alignment is crucial to ensure purely tensile loading; any misalignment introduces bending moments that affect the results.

Therefore, while the tensile test provides a useful estimate of bonding strength, results should be interpreted as indicative values rather than absolute measurements. Multiple samples and complementary characterization methods (such as the razor blade test) are recommended for comprehensive bonding quality assessment. **INCLUDE OUR OWN EXPERIMENT HERE**

4.6 Leak Tests using Spectroscopy

Once the cell is sealed and activated with the alkali metal vapor (typically Rb or Cs), leak tests can be performed over time to estimate its hermeticity. Leak tests involving laser absorption spectroscopy have been reported in literature [78, 79, 80, 81, 82]. In these tests, a tunable laser interacts with the alkali atoms. By measuring the width and central frequency of the resulting absorption profile, the internal environment of the cell can be monitored.

The optical transitions of alkali metals are characterized by the so-called D-line doublet. This fine structure arises from the spin-orbit interaction, which splits the first excited state (nP) into two distinct energy levels: $n^2P_{1/2}$ and $n^2P_{3/2}$. The transition from the ground state $n^2S_{1/2}$ to the lower excited state $n^2P_{1/2}$ is known as the D1 line, while the transition to the higher state $n^2P_{3/2}$ is the D2 line. These transitions are illustrated in Figure 4.11.

Collisions between the alkali atoms and other gas molecules perturb the atomic energy levels, leading to collision-induced broadening and a frequency shift. If the cell's hermeticity is compromised and atmospheric gases leak into the cell, the resulting increase in internal pressure (P) will cause

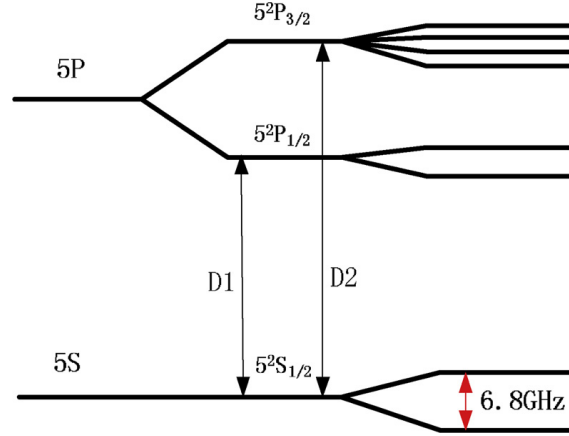


Figure 4.11: Energy level diagram showing the D1 and D2 transitions in an alkali metal atom. From [82]

a detectable width broadening and a frequency shift of the Lorentzian profile. To quantify the gas pressure, the following relations are used:

$$\delta\nu = \delta P \quad (4.8)$$

$$\Delta\nu_L = \gamma P + \gamma_N \quad (4.9)$$

The first equation relates the frequency shift ($\delta\nu$) to the pressure (P) through the shift rate constant (δ). The second equation links the pressure to the Lorentzian full width at half maximum ($\Delta\nu_L$), involving the broadening rate constant γ and the natural linewidth γ_N .

Both δ and γ depend on the specific alkali-gas pair and the temperature, with values documented in literature [78, 79, 80, 81, 82]. Furthermore, the broadening rate γ at a temperature T_2 can be estimated from a known value at T_1 using:

$$\gamma(T_2) = \gamma(T_1) \left(\frac{T_1}{T_2} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} \quad (4.10)$$

Note that the shift constant δ does not follow such a simple scaling law due to its more complex temperature dependence [78]

4.6.1 Experimental Proposal

The spectroscopic framework described above can be directly applied to assess the hermeticity of the fabricated vapor cells. Here, an experimental procedure similar to the one followed by Maurice et al. [83] is described.

First, the sealed and activated cell is heated to a nominal operating temperature T_{op} —chosen so that the alkali vapor pressure is sufficient to produce a measurable absorption signal—and held there throughout the measurement campaign using a temperature-stabilized mount. Temperature stability is critical, since any drift in T_{op} would introduce a systematic error in the extracted pressure through the temperature dependence of γ and δ [78].

A tunable laser is scanned across the D1 or D2 absorption line and the transmitted intensity is recorded with a photodetector. To avoid power broadening, the probe beam intensity is kept well below the saturation intensity of the transition. The resulting spectrum is fitted to a Voigt profile, from which the Lorentzian width $\Delta\nu_L$ and the line center ν_0 are extracted. Since the Doppler width depends only on T_{op} and the atomic mass, the Lorentzian component is unambiguously separated. The internal pressure is then retrieved using Equations 4.8 and 4.9, evaluated at T_{op} using literature values of γ and scaled if necessary via Equation 4.10. The two estimates of P —one from the width and one from the frequency shift—serve as a mutual consistency check.

Spectra are recorded at regular time intervals: initially daily, and subsequently weekly once short-term stability has been confirmed. The pressure $P(t)$ is plotted as a function of time and, in the case of a small but non-zero leak, a linear fit to $P(t)$ yields the leak rate $\dot{P}$. If no detectable increase is observed, the measurement noise propagated through Equation 4.9 sets an upper bound on the leak rate:

$$\sigma_P = \frac{\sigma_{\Delta\nu_L}}{\gamma(T_{\text{op}})} \quad (4.11)$$

where $\sigma_{\Delta\nu_L}$ is the uncertainty on the fitted Lorentzian width. This bound provides a physically meaningful hermeticity statement even in the absence of a detectable leak, and allows direct comparison with benchmarks from the literature: the 707-day vacuum integrity demonstrated by Artusio-Glimpse et al. [20] using Rydberg EIT spectroscopy, and the short-term seal integrity inferred from CPT resonance stability by Kobtsev et al. [84] over timescales up to ~ 1000 s.

Chapter 5

Experiments & Applications

5.1 Rail Tracks Corrosion Inspection

5.2 Atomic Clocks

5.3 Magnetoencephalography

5.4 Magnetometry Experiments on Vapor Cells

In this experiment that we performed at the facilities of the Physics Department at the *Politecnico di Bari* (POLIBA) in Bari, Italy, the goal was to demonstrate the capacity of vapor cells to serve as precise magnetometers in a laboratory setting. As described in [1, 85], when circularly polarized light interacts with alkali atoms (such as Rubidium or Cesium), it *transfers* some of its angular momentum into the gas. This effectively generates a non-zero electron spin polarization state inside the vapor cell.

In the presence of an external magnetic field $\vec{B}$, the atomic spins undergo Larmor precession at the frequency:

$$\omega_L = \gamma B \quad (5.1)$$

where γ is the gyromagnetic ratio (2π 3.5 kHz/G for Cesium-133). This precession modulates the projection of the atomic spin along the probe beam direction, causing periodic variations in the optical absorption and thus in the transmitted light intensity detected by the photodiode. When a linear magnetic field ramp—such as $B(t) = B_0 + \alpha t$ —is applied across the vapor cell, the transmitted light intensity exhibits a Lorentzian resonance peak centered at $B = 0$. This phenomenon, known as *Hanle resonance*, arises from the following mechanism:

For $B \neq 0$, the Zeeman sublevels ($m_F = -F, -F + 1, \dots, +F$) are non-degenerate and precess at different rates, leading to dephasing of the atomic coherences. This dephasing destroys the spin polarization created by optical pumping, resulting in increased absorption and reduced transmission.

At $B = 0$, all Zeeman sublevels become degenerate, eliminating the precession-induced dephasing. The atomic coherences remain phase-locked, maintaining maximal spin polarization in the

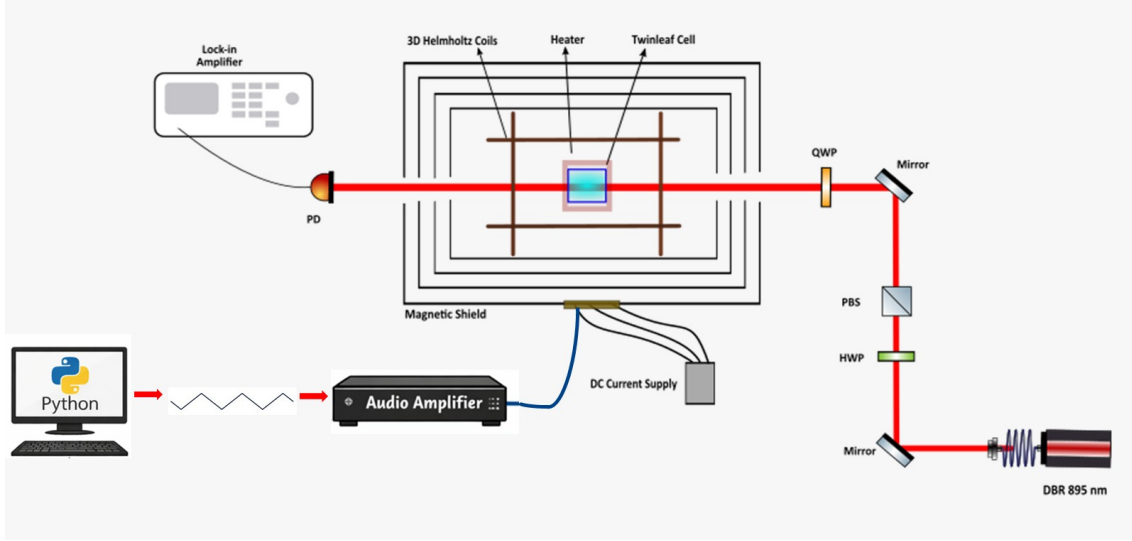


Figure 5.1: Experimental setup used to detect Hanle resonance

direction of the pump beam. Atoms in this polarized state exhibit reduced absorption for the circularly polarized probe light, producing a transmission maximum.

By analyzing the Lorentzian profile, properties of the vapor cell, such as the coherence lifetime (τ), can be determined. The relationship between the Lorentzian full width at half maximum (FWHM) and τ is given by:

$$\Delta B_{\text{FWHM}} \sim \frac{1}{\gamma\tau} \quad (5.2)$$

5.4.1 Experimental Setup

A Twinleaf Vapor Cell, filled with Cesium and Nitrogen as buffer gas, was placed inside a magnetic shield to isolate it from background noise (e.g., Earth's magnetic field). A laser tuned to the D1 transition of Cs — $\lambda = 895 \text{ nm}$ — is directed into the vapor cell. To control the power of the incoming light, a half-wave plate (HWP) and a polarizing beam splitter (PBS) were employed. Just before entering the magnetic shield, a quarter-wave plate (QWP) is placed to generate a circularly polarized beam.

Inside the magnetic shield, coils are used to generate an alternating magnetic field ramp ($B_x = B_0 + \alpha t$) along the beam axis (X-axis). As explained previously, this time-dependent field generates a time-dependent absorption profile, which is detected by a photodetector placed outside the magnetic cavity and connected to a lock-in amplifier. To correct for background noise, DC fields are applied along the Z- and Y-axes. This experiment was carried at room temperature. An illustration of this setup is displayed in Figure 5.1.

5.4.2 Results and Analysis

Measurements were made using different DC field configurations to study their effects on Lorentzian peak height, width, and noise. Figure 5.2 compares the fitted Lorentzian profiles detected by the photodetector for different DC field configurations.

From these results, it can be deduced that the chosen DC field configuration greatly affects the sharpness of the observed Hanle resonance. Signal amplitudes below 10 mV are obtained for the least optimal configuration ($B_y = 3600$ nT, $B_z = 0$ nT), while peaks greater than 40 mV are achieved with the configuration $B_y = 0$ nT, $B_z = 4815$ nT.

In conclusion, for this specific experimental setup, applying a DC field in the Y direction reduces the amplitude and increases the FWHM of the Hanle resonance, whereas a DC field in the Z direction has the opposite effect.

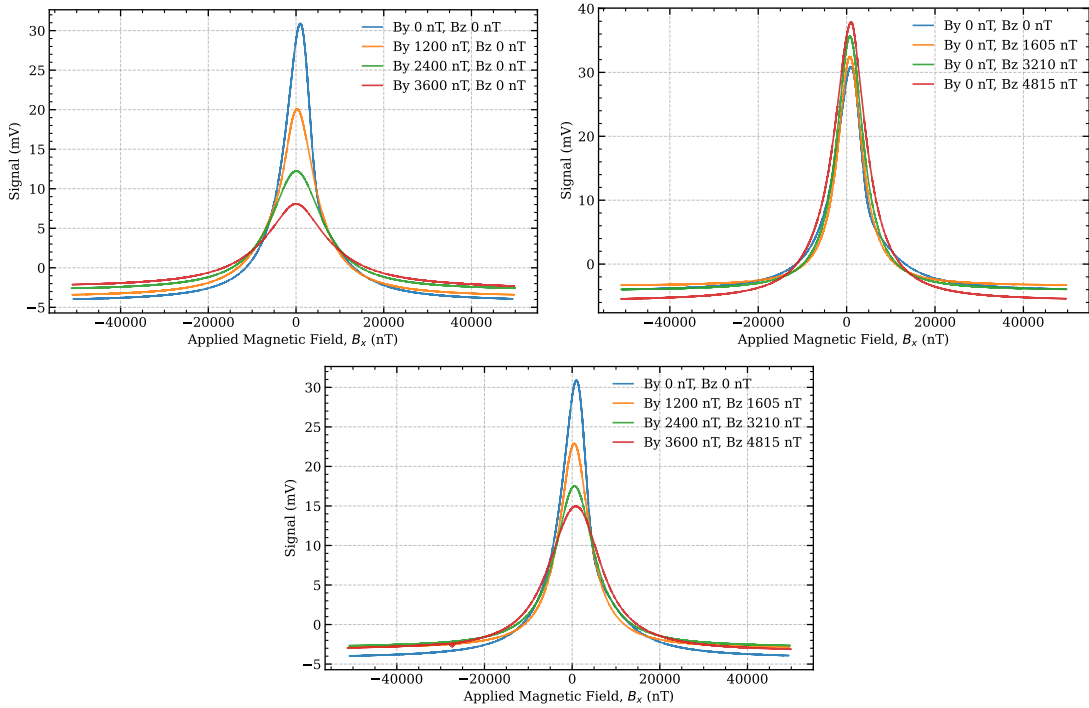


Figure 5.2: Lorentzian profiles when (a) B_z is varied and $B_y = 0$, (b) B_y is varied and $B_z = 0$, and (c) B_y and B_z are varied simultaneously

Since the goal of this experiment is to study Hanle resonances, the configuration $B_y = 0$ nT, $B_z = 4815$ nT was further analyzed. Figure 5.3 shows the raw data and Lorentzian fit for this configuration. The amplitude of the resonance signal is 42.2 mV. It can be observed that the Lorentzian's maximum is not located exactly at the origin, but is displaced slightly to the right ($B_x = 865.5$ nT). This effect is observed systematically and can be attributed to background noise and electronic effects. A FWHM of 8726.3 nT is estimated. From this value, and using 5.2, the relaxation time of this cell at room temperature is ~ 50 ms.

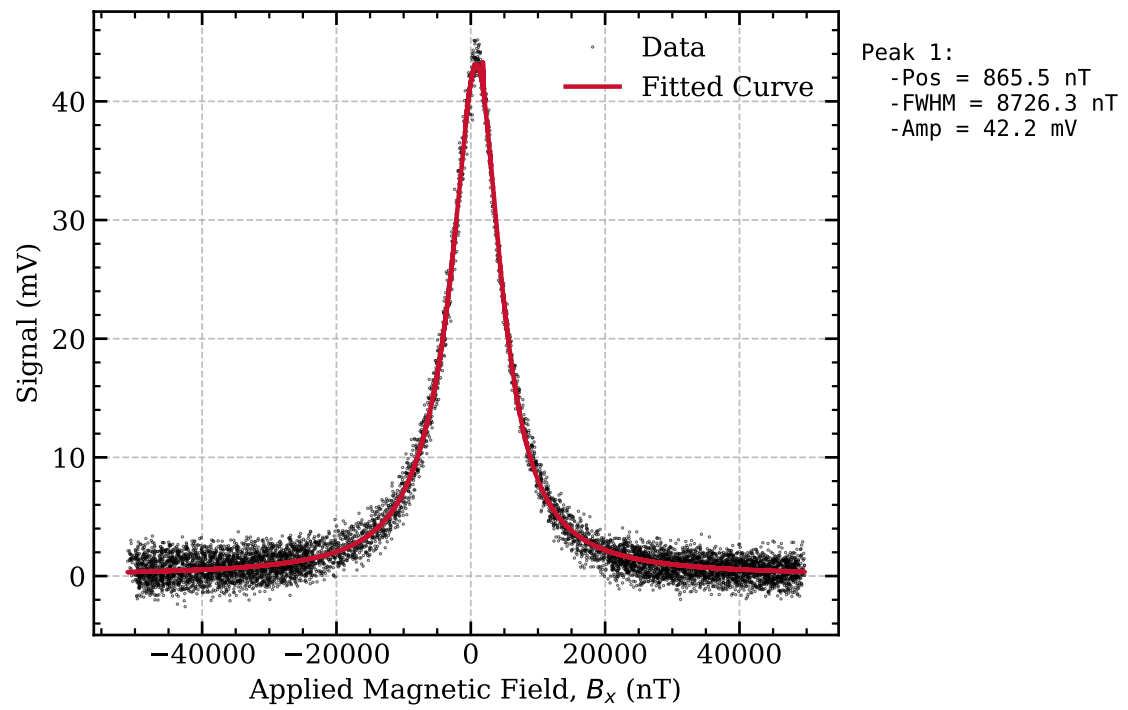


Figure 5.3: Raw data and Lorentzian fit of the Hanle resonance obtained for the optimal DC field configuration ($B_y = 0$ nT, $B_z = 4815$ nT)

Chapter 6

Conclusions

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Part II

Annex

Appendix A

Recipes in Literature

A.1 Recipes in literature

Table A.1: Summary of chemical cleaning procedures, surface activation methods, and resulting bonding qualities.

Reference	Chemical Cleaning Steps							Surface Activation	Post-Treatment	Bonding Strength
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7			
Domenico Tuli Thesis	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.06 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	—	—	—	—	—	—	Plasma 30s 15W 35mTorr	—	0.06 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Micro Soap 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	—	—	—	0.06 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	RCA1 10' 60°C	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	—	—	—	0.06 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	RCA1 10' 60°C	NH ₄ OH 2' 25°C	—	—	—	—	—	0.06 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Micro Soap 10' 25°C	RCA1 10' 60°C	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	—	—	0.06 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Micro Soap 10' 25°C	RCA1 10' 60°C	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	—	—	0.1 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Micro Soap 10' 25°C	RCA1 10' 60°C	NH ₄ OH 2' 25°C	—	—	—	—	0.1 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Piranha 10' 60°C	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	—	Plasma 30s 15W 35mTorr	—	0.1 J/m ²
	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Piranha 10' 60°C	DIW 10' 25°C	Micro Soap 10' 25°C	RCA1 10' 60°C	DIW 10' 25°C	—	—	0.1 J/m ²
Cho et al. 2001	HF (dipped)	Piranha 15'	RCA1 15'	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 15-120s 50-300W	Annealing 50h >105°C	2.5 J/m ²
	RCA1	RCA2	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 40s 30W 1atm	Annealing 6h 120°C	2.2 J/m ²
Li et al. 2013	SC1 10' 80°C	SC2 10' 80s	DIW (rinse)	RCA1 10' 60°C	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 60s 50W 20mTorr	Press. 3x10 ⁵ Pa → Annealing 6h 200-800°C	11 MPa BS
Wang et al. 2020	Acetone	Ethanol	DIW	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 90s 200W 375mTorr	Wait 12h Room T → Annealing 12h 150°C	5.5 MPa BS
Takei et al. 2010	RCA1 10' 70°C	DIW (rinse)	HF 2%	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 30s 400W 900mTorr	Annealing 8h 250°C 5MPa	1 MPa BS
Lee et al. 2022	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	N ₂ Plasma 15s 100W 100mTorr	DIW → Annealing 1-4h 200-500°C	2.5x w/o plasma
Suni et al. 2002	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	N ₂ Plasma 30s 50-150W	RCA1 → DIW 5' → Annealing → Dicing → Annealing	>2.5 J/m ²
	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 45s 50-150W	Annealing 2h 100°C → Dicing → Annealing 2h 200°C	~2.5 J/m ²
Park et al. 2025	Piranha	HF dip	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 30s 800W 800mTorr	Press. 5' 5000mBar → Annealing 1h 400°C	~1.7 J/m ²
Our proc. (P11-P13)	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 5' + dry	Piranha 10' 75°C	DIW 5' + dry	RCA1 10' 75°C	DIW 5' + dry	—	O ₂ Plasma 60s 30W 1200mTorr	DIW 5' → Annealing >12h 150°C	TBD
	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 120s 30W 1200mTorr		
	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 180s 30W 1200mTorr		
Our proc. (P21-P23)	Acetone 10' 25°C	DIW 5' + dry	Piranha 10' 75°C	DIW 5' + dry	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 60s 30W 1200mTorr	DIW 5' → Annealing >12h 150°C	TBD
	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 120s 30W 1200mTorr		
	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	O ₂ Plasma 180s 30W 1200mTorr		